

### CHAPTER THREE

#### THE UNIVERSAL TOWN MEETING

In the previous chapter we examined the environment in which the modern newspaper first appeared-- the city. We concluded that the city as a social structure created the need for a new form of news, the human interest story, which helped to orient and entertain the new urban masses. These functions are not the same as the information functions classically associated with the press. Human interest stories do not refer to an unfolding world of events in which action must be taken on the basis of fresh data. They do not, in other words, "inform the public." But neither are they merely the expression of a childish desire to be shocked and entertained. The human interest story originates in the breaking apart of the communal environment, in the disappearance of the world Jefferson thought most favorable to democracy. The penny papers became a popular medium by exploiting the value of the human interest item, in effect capitalizing on the loss of coherence which the transition to an urban environment implies. In this chapter we explore the vision of press and public which grew out of this success-- a vision which, as

we shall see, ignored the contradictions inherent in the rise of a modern press.

Perhaps the most successful human interest story ever, and certainly the most important one in the rise of the penny press, was not a story at all but a hoax-- the "Great Moon Hoax" perpetrated by the Sun in 1835. The Sun reported one day that an immense new telescope employed by Sir John Herschell at the Cape of Good Hope had shown evidence of men on the moon. Over the next week increasingly sensational accounts of Herschell's "discoveries" filled the pages of the paper, stirring up so much interest that even the staid six-cent journals began picking up the story, as did European papers. The stunt climaxed with descriptions of winged creatures the Sun called "man-bats," which were said to be inhabiting the moon (Hughes 185). Eventually the man who had written the story for the Sun confessed to a rival paper and the hoax was exposed. Other papers berated the Sun for its conduct, but most people seemed to think it was all in good fun (Mott, American Journalism 226).

Perhaps, as Hughes argues, the Great Moon Hoax simply appealed to a universal interest in the heavens, something "that everyone has speculated on at one time or another" (186). But there is another way to interpret the incident-- as a logical extension of the Sun's approach to the human drama of the city. Like the city spectacle, the moon is both distant and near, easy to see, impossible to know.

That is what makes it a mystery. Moreover, what the hoax described is how life is lived on the moon, exactly the appeal of other human interest stories written closer to home. The Sun was in the business of widening the world of its readers, of astonishing and delighting them by giving detail to the dim apprehension of other lives being lived in their midst. Why not take the logical step to the moon and describe life as it is lived there? In this sense, it is not surprising that the common man refused to be outraged by the falsehoods in the hoax. For if the stories were scientifically false, they were humanly true: that is, their aim was true. They hit a spot on the popular imagination and held on. Accuracy, then, is a relative term. When news functions as information, something resembling scientific standards can prevail: accuracy proves itself in the physical world. Either it happened this way, or it did not. But when the functions of news are symbolic, (and the motives of the press commercial) accuracy is a statement about the audience and what it needs or desires or expects from its reports. Some stories fit themselves accurately to the interests of the audience, others do not. This is undoubtedly what William Randolph Hearst meant when he distinguished the really interesting news from the "merely important" (qtd. in Hughes 57). One of the most significant histories to be uncovered in the study of the press is therefore the history of the means by which the interests of

the audience are judged-- in short, the history of feedback in journalism. For it is the closeness of this "fit" with the audience, and not a fidelity to fact, which has spelled success in the newspaper business.

#### Street sales as feedback

No one understood this better than James Gordon Bennett, the editor of the New York Herald and undoubtedly the most important figure in the rise of the mass circulation newspaper. In an 1866 profile of Bennett reviewing his long and tumultuous career, the North American Review noted that he began the Herald by working sixteen hour days as the paper's only reporter, editor, salesman and make-up man, rushing out to gather the news in the day and back to the office to put it into print at night:

He converted himself, as it were, into a medium through which the gossip, scandal, fun, and nonsense of this great town were daily conveyed back to it for its amusement; just as a certain popular preacher is reported to do, who spends six days in circulating among his parishoners, and on the seventh tells them all that they have taught him. (395)

Here is another way of phrasing the distinction we elaborated in the previous chapter. In publishing whatever "gossip, scandal, fun and nonsense" he could find, Bennett made the newspaper a medium through which the city could communicate with itself. A kind of circularity thus enters the relation between journalism and its audience: Bennett gives back to the city the human comedy it stages each day.



In contrast to this circular flow, news as information moves in a linear fashion from margin to center, from distant front to home office, from the scene of action to the breakfast table. It is what Smith referred to as "intelligence," word of what is happening in the outer world. As soon as intelligence begins to conform not to the shape of events but to the habits or expectations of the person receiving it, it is useless as intelligence. In fact, it is dangerous. Just this possibility has provided the intrigue in any number of spy novels: the chance that intelligence is not flowing in a linear fashion from margin to center but has been short circuited and given a human plan. That the agency may be unknowingly communicating with itself through reports falsified in a deliberate fashion offers the novelist a ready-made drama, for the nature of intelligence work is that it depends on information produced "naturally," that is, without regard for its intended audience. Human interest news is not innocent of its audience in this way.

Nor was Bennett. He had a feel for what would excite, amuse and enrage. But he had something ultimately more important than that: his sales figures, a daily measure of his success in enabling the city to communicate with itself. The significance of the mass circulation newspaper sold on the streets is not simply in the number of papers sold and the scale of the enterprise, but in the information value of

the sales themselves. For the first time, a sense of what the audience desired to read in its newspaper could be gained by daily trial and error. And there were plenty of errors, papers begun on a hunch and gone in a few weeks, wrong guesses and false starts that disappeared from the streets with hardly a trace and passed out of press history<sup>1</sup> before they could enter it. A century before there was market research or statistics there was this elementary form of feedback, in which the audience sent daily messages to the newspaper about what messages to send, simply by buying or refusing to buy the paper.<sup>2</sup> As Frank M. O'Brien wrote in his study of the Sun:

The assassination of Czar Alexander II of Russia did not sell an extra paper, but the hanging of Foster, the "car-hook" murderer, sent the sales up seventeen thousand. The deaths of Cornelius Vanderbilt and Alexander T. Stewart had no effect on the Sun's circulation, the passing of Napoleon III raised it only one thousand for the day, and the death of Pius IX caused only four thousand irregular readers to buy the paper, but the execution of Dolan, a murderer now practically forgotten, sent the sales up ten thousand. (qtd. in Hughes 9)

This was the important information the penny papers dealt in: the signals sent by the emerging mass audience to the publishers. The sixpenny journals had precluded the possibility of such a feedback mechanism by requiring a yearly subscription, a one-time decision with very little information value. (In fact, the decision to subscribe meant so little to subscribers that they often neglected to

pay. Before streets sales bad debts were a chronic problem for the newspaper.)

### Readers as writers

Bennett got the first strong signal from his audience through his coverage of the Helen Jewett murder in 1836. A beautiful prostitute was found dead in a fashionable house of sin and a young clerk was accused of the crime. Bennett, realizing that the clerk could be made into a sympathetic figure, built up the story as a tale of scandal in high places, describing champagne parties at the house attended by businessmen and charging that the young man accused of the crime had been framed. By the time the clerk was acquitted the Herald's circulation had tripled during the run of the story, mostly because of Bennett's eyewitness accounts and dramatic reconstructions of the murder and trial (Mott, American Journalism 233). Throughout the scandal Bennett had functioned as an extension of the audience's senses, describing in vivid detail the inside of the house, the bedroom where the murder occurred and the look of the corpse as a policeman lifted the sheets to show him (Hughes 12). Before the interview had become standard practice in journalism, Bennett reproduced in question and answer form his conversation with the woman who discovered the body. He did the same for trial testimony. What he provided his readers was a vicarious thrill, a visit inside

a hidden world that had been broken open in spectacular fashion.

In his coverage of the Jewett murder, Bennett was not so much uncovering facts as completing an image that had been dimly drawn in the minds of his readers before the incident. People had known about the house of prostitution; they had perhaps passed by it, whispering of what went on there. Vice was an atmosphere given off by the city, a dark side of the urban drama that no one could fail to notice, whether they felt tempted or not. By describing the scene of an actual crime Bennett gave form to a known but invisible underworld: he filled in what had been outlined in the imagination of his readers. Naturally the form he gave was exaggerated, for it was designed to complete an image rather than furnish the facts. Thus, the prostitute was not simply beautiful, she was beauty itself. As Bennett described her corpse:

The body looked as white, as full, as polished, as the purest Parian marble. The perfect figure, the exquisite limbs, the fine face, the full arms, the beautiful bust, all, all surpassed in every respect the Venus de Medici, according to the casts generally given of her. (qtd. in Hughes 12)

As a form of communication this sort of report is more complex than it might appear. Bennett writes as if he is describing what he was shown, testifying as a witness, but his rendering owes as much to the audience's expectations as it does to the scene itself. It describes the way his



readers might picture a beautiful woman, and in that sense is a message returned to the audience by the journalist as much as it is a report from the scene of action. Throughout the Helen Jewett scandal readers were informing Bennett about what they wanted to read, and Bennett was communicating back to the readers what the sales figures were telling him. By reacting himself with awe and outrage, Bennett was exhibiting the emotions his readers were inclined to have, and the tale began to be shaped by these demands--the logic of the story--rather than a strict desire to uncover the facts. In a sense the readers were acting as authors and Bennett as medium, an extension of their eyes, ears and curiosity.

That readers were also writers was something Jefferson had realized about newspapers long before the human interest story became a staple of the press. In advising a man who had written him about starting a newspaper, Jefferson said he thought the press of his own time so irresponsible that "defamation is becoming a necessary of life," a stimulant even reasonable people seem to need. Those who should know better read these outrageous items, forgetting the fact "that it is not he who prints, but he who pays for printing a slander, who is its real author."<sup>3</sup> Jefferson no doubt meant that moral responsibility for the sad condition of the press must be shared by readers, but his remark also points up the role of the reader in shaping the content of the

newspaper. The newspaper audience is not simply spoken to-- it speaks, both to the newspaper and through the newspaper to itself. As Tocqueville put it, "Newspapers make associations and associations make newspapers" (2: 112).

### Instant community

The press is a means by which a group realizes itself as a group. And this happens because the press communicates not only from margin to center, from distant front to breakfast table, but also from heart to heart, in its expression of common sentiment, and from heart to head in the detail it gives to feelings vaguely perceived. Why do we eagerly turn to newspaper accounts of events we attended and already know about? Because it is exciting to see our experience transformed into a public report. We see things in a different light and feel connected to some small movement of history, regardless of whether we learn anything from the account. As the North American Review observed in 1866:

The newspaper is that which connects each individual with the general life of mankind, and makes him part and parcel of the whole; so that we can almost say, that those who neither read newspapers nor converse with people who do read them are not members of the human family; -- that is, not actually, not now; though, like the negroes of Guinea, they may become such in time. They are beyond the pale; they have no hold of the electric chain, and therefore do not receive the shock. (emphasis in original; 377)

Bennett made sure his readers received the shock. But that was not all there was to the Herald. True, Bennett

built a profitable circulation by abandoning the "important" for the "interesting." Yet he then turned around and used the profits to finance the paper's extensive information-gathering system, a network of correspondents superior to anything the press had previously seen and capable of providing fresh reports from increasingly distant places. This made the Herald an important paper for all classes, but what originally made it a popular and profitable paper was its proprietor's success in conveying the "gossip, scandal, fun and nonsense" of the town back to its inhabitants. Thus, the Herald led a schizoid existence: outrageous and inflammatory in its attempt to interest a mass audience and, at the same time, remarkably enterprising in its news coverage.<sup>4</sup> Because of the contradictory nature of his paper's appeal, Bennett could never shake his reputation as a charlatan and profiteer, despite his success in furnishing important information and biting analysis along with the scandal and amusement (North American Review 381).

In his attempt to steer a middle course between the simple sensationalism of papers like the Sun and the dull and spiritless quality of the commercial press, Bennett gave birth to a vision of the newspaper as a great unifying force. In May of 1835, shortly after the Herald's debut, Bennett remarked that:

The small daily papers around us were solely directed to mere police reports, melancholy accidents, or curious extracts. They indicated no mind, no

intelligence, no knowledge of society at large. The larger [papers] were many of them without talent and without interest. There was plenty of room, therefore, for a cheap paper managed on our plan, calculated to circulate among all ranks and conditions; to interest the merchant and man of learning, as well as the mechanic and the man of labor. (qtd. in Bleyer 187)

The fact that one newspaper could circulate among all classes, as the Herald did, led to an image of all classes as one class, attuned to the importance of world affairs and informed of their progress swiftly and efficiently through the news pages. It was as if the newspaper itself--in particular, the fact that it communicated so widely--could break down class barriers, even out cultural differences and send the light of understanding shining through to everyone for the mere price of a penny. Benjamin Day shared this dream, despite the fact that his Sun deliberately neglected politics, the traditional art of uniting men. "Already we can perceive a change in the mass of the people," he wrote in 1837. "They think, talk, and act in concert. They understand their own interest, and feel they have numbers and strength to pursue it with success" (qtd. in Bleyer 164). The vision of mass communication bringing instant community did not stop at the city or nation but took in the entire world. It was simply assumed that the ability to reach everyone would eliminate conflict and unite humanity. The great Christian dream of a world-wide brotherhood was now within reach. The North American Review reasoned that,



since it is isolation and ignorance that pits nation against nation and citizen against foreigner, the newspaper could not help but erase these conflicts, for it was obvious that the newspaper was ending isolation and ignorance. The newspaper "constitutes a universal town meeting for politics," the Review concluded (Savage 140).

Exactly the conflict we saw Jefferson wrestling with in the first chapter is here resolved in the notion of a "universal town meeting." The town meeting is the ideal image of a democracy at work. It can carry this ideal because the town is a limited environment, where problems are small in scale and competence in governing can be safely assumed. A republic is a government that has outgrown the boundaries of a small town; it is democracy extended over distance and thus conducted through symbols-- flags which represent the nation, people who represent other people, news reports which represent events occurring at a distance, campaigns which represent the principle of "government by the people" when the people cannot directly govern. Jefferson believed that the press was vital to the health of the republic because it enabled people to participate in a government that had been removed from their immediate grasp. But he also believed that this removal was inherently dangerous, for it was always threatening to widen into tyranny. Thus Jefferson sought to preserve the political functions of the small local community. He wanted to give

the town meeting as much business as possible in order to minimize the dangers of distance, the very factor that gave the press its sacred place in the republic. The idea of a "universal town meeting" erases this conflict between small town democracy and physical distance. It holds that people can manage their own affairs and find a way to unite even when scattered all over the globe. They can accomplish this because the newspaper restores the conditions of the small town by wiping out the factor of distance.

### The telegraph and the electronic mythos

In effect, this vision of the newspaper wipes out the idea of a republic as well, for it eliminates the need to go through intermediaries like nations, laws and legislators. People are wired directly to one another. "The day of universal reading has dawned," said the Review, "universal thinking will follow" (141). What is really destroyed in the bypassing of the republic is the dependence on all symbols, all media, all means by which people are brought into contact with one another and with collective concerns, (and yet remain separate.) Thus the idea that universal reading leads to universal thinking: the medium dissolves. Ironically it was the arrival of a new medium, the telegraph, that put this fantastic idea in so many heads. Bennett wrote in 1845 that with this magic invention,

The public mind will be stimulated to greater activity by the rapid circulation of news. The swift communication of tidings of great events, will awake

in the masses of the community still keener interest in public affairs.... The whole nation is impressed with the same idea at the same moment. One feeling and one impulse are thus created and maintained from the centre of the land to its uttermost extremities. (qtd. in Pray 364)

In an 1851 editorial on the telegraph and the mission of the press, Samuel Bowles extended the vision beyond the nation to the globe. In partnership with the newspaper, Bowles wrote, the telegraph promised "to melt and mould the jarring and contending nations of the world into that one great brotherhood which, through long centuries, has been the ideal of the Christian and the philanthropist."<sup>6</sup> Why did the telegraph give rise to these utopian visions? The question is worth a study in itself, but here we can make some speculative remarks. Communication always appears to promise an increase in human control. Word of what is happening in distant places make it possible to direct the course of distant events, bringing more and more territory under the conscious direction of men. Communication, then, seems to expand the scope of the mind. It makes everything amenable to judgment and the revision of judgment based on new information. (In effect, it enlarges the domain of the present, for custom and tradition--those ways in which things have always been done--lose their authority in human affairs when constant action and reaction are possible through a steady supply of information. When control over distance is enlarged, those who have the latest information

hold the authority.) A tremendous sense of power accompanies the reach of modern communications; it is literally the feeling of power over the world, of control following inevitably from contact with events. Frederic Hudson, Bennett's managing editor, used military metaphors to express this feeling in his history of American journalism. In describing the journalist in the age of the telegraph he wrote:

With dispatches from every quarter and nation of the earth continually pouring into the editor's office, the face of the globe becomes to him a vast field of battle-- the desperate battle of life, and he is placed like a Napoleon, surrounded by his staff, to decide at once what is to be done, and to act.  
(600)

The telegraph was the ideal medium for nourishing this sense of power, for it seemed to represent contact in the abstract, communication as simple fact, unadorned by language or symbol. This quality of abstractness also allowed other mythical meanings to collect around the medium. Electricity resembled thought itself and the electric telegraph the direct transmission of thought. In an essay on "The Mythos of the Electronic Revolution," James Carey and John J. Quirk make the point that, because electricity sends messages invisibly, "there is a persistent attempt to link it with an extrasensory and wordless world that can be entered in an unmediated way." As a metaphor for the modern world, electricity gives rise to the dream of "cosmic awareness, a bypassing of communication, a loss of



self and [a] direct unmediated participation in the totality of life and knowledge" (420). Electric communication thus allowed two contradictory impulses to merge, Carey and Quirk argue. On the one hand it offered power over nature by annihilating space and giving men like Hudson the feeling of control over distant events. On the other hand it seemed to promise a kind of communion with nature and with other men, a restoration of the harmony that must have existed before the machine, or as the authors put it, a "providential bond between man and his environment" (418). With the telegraph, the urges to dominate nature and become one with it were collapsed into a single utopian vision, one version of which was the "universal town meeting," an ideal political unit which both extended the control of space to its final limit and, at the same time, restored the close, communal life that existed before the community's extension in space began.

#### Universal citizenship through the press

It is important to keep in mind that the combination of the telegraph and the mass circulation newspaper is what gave birth to this faith, for the dream is a dream of instant transmission and total distribution. In his analysis of the "grand moral claims made on behalf of the telegraph," Daniel J. Czitrom observes that those who predicted a new world harmony through the miracle of

communication were mingling two meanings the term had gained, the archaic sense of the word, in which to communicate means to make common, to commune, and the modern sense, having to do with conveying information. The "ambiguity between the two poles of meaning" went unresolved, he concludes (10-11). This ambiguity tended to obscure the contradictory effects of communication over distance-- the fact that, as the scale of social organization increase, the authority of the community dissolves. Selves are set free from the bonds of the past, neighbors become strangers and strangers neighbors. Tradition and custom count for less, technology and information for more. Carey and Quirk point to Harold Innis as the thinker who best understood this relation (389). Innis did not assume that an enlarged ability to communicate would enlarge the community. Rather, one tended to destroy the other, for the extension of social organization across space undermined the oral tradition, the carrier of culture, by making face to face contacts less important and eliminating the concern for what endured over time.<sup>7</sup>

We have already seen how the mass circulation newspaper was a part of this process. It appeared first in the city, offering a new form of sociability in an environment where face to face contacts, though frequent, were distant and speechless. Thus the newspaper actually arose from the absence of community, the human interest story emerging, for

example, from the mutual ignorance that characterized social relations in the city. It is only when people do not care about each other and feel no responsibility for each other's fate that they are willing to be entertained by human interest items. The vision of the newspaper as a community-creator comes partly from the breadth of its distribution. The newspaper can reach everyone in the community. With the telegraph, one community could be put into touch with every other community. Add the telegraph to the newspaper and everyone could be in touch with everyone else through the press, for as Czitrom points out, it was the newspaper that brought the magic of the telegraph to the millions by publishing telegraphed news. Most people never actually used the device to send messages; it entered their lives through the press (14).

All the varieties of the faith we have been examining assume two things. One is that presenting information to people is equivalent to informing them. Since information from everywhere can now be presented to everyone, everyone can now be informed about everything. According to Anthony Smith, one of the aims of the modern newspaper "has been to create the impression--perhaps the illusion--that all information is the true business of all its readers." The newspaper offers people "an implied universal citizenship by virtue of their acquaintanceship with the facts" in the paper, Smith argues (Goodbye Gutenberg 311). The

possibility of such "universal citizenship," (or what Walter Lippmann called the "omnicompetent citizen") follows logically from the telegraph's ability to transmit news from anywhere. The second assumption is communication as communion, the idea that shared information leads to shared understanding and common action-- by itself. The traditional ways of uniting men, through political action and persuasive rhetoric, through the elaboration of a shared creed (as in religion), were deemed to be obsolete. It was the magic fact of communication that would unite men, and the newspaper, the fullest extension of that fact, would take the lead and become the great civilizing force of the modern world.

#### Contradictions of a freed press

The faith that information can unite men and lead them to the truth was not, of course, born with the mass circulation newspaper. It had been a part of the arguments for freedom of expression since those arguments began to be made. But the faith in the delivery of information alone, in the mere fact of communication, was a novel one. In an essay entitled "Two Revolutions in the American Press," Walter Lippmann went back to Milton's classic framing of the argument for free speech. He noted that Milton believed in free speech because he assumed, like those who followed him, that truth would win out over error. But he assumed this



because, as a Puritan, he also believed that "God revealed the truth directly to the faithful." Thus, "the freedom from external control" which Milton advocated in his arguments against government censorship assumed a kind of "inner control," a spiritual discipline that came from the common practice of religion (436). It was on that basis that Milton argued for free speech, (consistently excluding the rights of Catholics, Leonard W. Levy notes [95-100].) But an interesting thing happened in the long fight for freedom of the press, Lippmann observes. As the "external control decayed" and government lost its hold on the press, the "internal control dissolved" as well, and a secular culture began to triumph along with a free press. When, with the penny papers, the press finally emerged as profitable and genuinely free from government, the shared creed which had once bound people together was also gone. In its place was the market and the beginning of what we would now call mass culture. Lippmann writes:

Thus the popular commercial press of the second half of the nineteenth century and down to our times has had as its central motive the immediate satisfaction of the largest number of people. Its proprietors and editors had, of course, their own convictions, but the working principle [was] to catch the daily interest of their potential readers. Thus this press, escaped from the tutelage of government, fell under the tutelage of the masses. It was not a free press in the sense that it was moved by the convictions of its writers, but a kind of freedmen's press, which, lacking the positive qualities of a liberal existence, found support and profit in serving the whims and wishes and curiosity of the people. (436)

Lippmann's argument is that, by the time the press gained the power to truly say what it pleased, all it wanted to do was please the masses. It therefore exchanged one form of control for another: the dependence on party and a ruling class dissolved, but in its place was a slavish devotion to the market, that is, to whatever would excite or amuse its audience. Still, this was an important step, Lippmann argued; it established the press as a power any government had to respect. But the revolution was incomplete, for the object of this new press was

not to report events in their due relationships or to interpret them in ways that subsequent events will verify. It selects from the events of the day those aspects which most immediately engage attention, and in place of the effort to see life steadily and whole it sees life dramatically, episodically, and from what is called, in the jargon of the craft, the angle of human interest. (438)

This is what the utopian visions of the press had overlooked. True, it was now possible to deliver instant word of events from anywhere on earth. And word of those events could be in the hand of the common man by daybreak--also true. But the two facts do not make a whole. In particular, they do not make for a body of citizens interested in their common fate, informed about the world they live in and prepared to act for the common good. In short, they do not create an informed public. For while it is true that the newspaper for the first time began to address the mass of citizens, it did not address them as

citizens, but as a mass. (Exactly what a mass is will be taken up in the next chapter.) To again borrow from H.D. Duncan, people did not want "information about, but identification with" their surroundings. The penny press built its appeal on the feeling of participation it lent to its readers, on its ability to extend the senses, strip away the veils of strangers, give shape and color, name and detail to the urban drama, and to reflect in its own urgency and breadth the scope and power of an unfolding modernity. It discovered how to do this by exploiting a characteristic feature of mass communication: the daily exchange of messages with a large audience through the acts of buying and selling. The information the penny papers were most interested in did not concern the unfolding of events in the world of politics and public affairs. The cheap papers were founded, in fact, on a hostility toward that world. Rather, the important information was being sent by the audience to the publishers about what sort of newspaper might sell. It was this information, codified in the form and contents of the newspaper, that was profitable. And it was this information that was constantly being circulated, in different symbolic forms, through the community of readers the mass circulation newspaper had created. The audience was communicating in a new way with itself--not with the world--though it used this new form of communication to

experience its world in a fuller, more dramatic, more sensational, more enjoyable way.

### Ridiculing the public realm

The penny papers were funny: comic relief. And one of the things they offered relief from was the serious business of public affairs. Early on in the Herald's rise, Bennett, seeking to draw attention to his paper, wrote parodies of the news. For example, he published mock special messages from Andrew Jackson intended to make the common people laugh and to enrage the established journals (Pray 194). (On both counts he succeeded; circulation grew and the established journals later took revenge in the "Moral Wars" of the 1840s, Bennett exploiting every one of these attacks for its publicity value.) Bennett was so bent on ridiculing every party and principle, every form of belief, that press critic Will Irwin later wrote that in "his attitude toward the public interest, he appeared unmoral rather than immoral. He kept faith with no party, respected no privacy" (Propaganda and the News 46). Consider, then, the contradictions in Bennett's Herald. After it became profitable, it pursued important information with a vengeance, virtually inventing modern reporting and making itself indispensable to anyone concerned with the vital issues of politics, business, statecraft and war. At the same time it heaped ridicule on the public realm, refusing



to take seriously any public man's claim to principle and, more importantly, refusing to limit its news coverage to his public actions. If the serious and informed citizen can be defined in part by what he is not interested in, by what he refuses to hold against a man or consider relevant to a judgment about him; if the public realm, in short, excludes the private, thereby gaining its meaning, then Bennett was nothing less than a public menace, a man bent on erasing the line between public and private and exposing everything, not only to the glare of publicity, but also to his own dark sarcasm, sharpened to an edge by a true talent for the written word. Reviewing Bennett's career in 1899, E.L. Godkin wrote,

He introduced, too, an absolutely new feature, which has had, perhaps, the greatest success of all. I mean the plan of treating everything and everybody as somewhat of a joke, and the knowledge of everything about him, including his family affairs, as something to which the public is entitled. (qtd. in Bleyer 209)

To give some idea of what Godkin was talking about, Bennett suggested in 1836 that Americans ought to consider an emperor instead of a President. An autocracy could hardly be any worse than a republic headed by the buffoons running for office, he reasoned (North American Review 399). Of course, it is impossible to know how seriously he meant it, but that is the point: it was the seriousness of public affairs which was being questioned. The reason for this little digression is not to underline the excesses of

Bennett's character, (although they are interesting in themselves) but to view them as expressions of the hostility to politics and public affairs--in fact, to everything public--which the popular newspaper embodied. Far from a "universal town meeting," the mass circulation newspaper often constituted a popular comedy in which the business of the public realm was mocked and adulterated with scandalous material from the private. Why did this happen? The argument we have been constructing is that it did not happen because of the greed of publishers or the childishness of the masses. It happened because the conditions which gave rise to the mass circulation newspaper also undermined the possibility of its audience emerging as an "informed public."

### Summary

We can now begin to tie the various threads of our argument together. The newspaper finally gained its freedom by obtaining a profitable circulation. It obtained a profitable circulation through the methods of mass appeal, chiefly by discovering the power of the human interest story. The profits gained in this fashion not only freed the newspaper from government, but made possible the news gathering system which stretched across the continent and eventually around the world. It thus became possible to bring word of events happening almost anywhere to people's

homes the next day. The telegraph wedded to the newspaper seemed to promise a universally informed public, for the one brought information instantly from almost anywhere and the other put it in the hands of almost everyone. But behind this vision was the questionable assumption that providing information is all there is to informing people. We have argued that such an assumption is false. The information functions of news are made possible not by the fact of transmitting messages from one place to another, but by certain characteristics the audience shares. These include a structural grasp of the environment, which makes it possible to place events in relation to one another; and along with this structure, the need to act and continually revise one's actions in light of new information.

There was nothing in the arrival of the telegraph or the rise of the mass circulation newspaper which ensured the spread of these conditions to the great mass of people. In fact, the opposite possibility is more likely: the conditions which give rise to the modern newspaper are also those which prevent its audience from emerging as an informed public. A certain loss of coherence, a splitting apart of the common world into the separate worlds of each inhabitant, helps give the modern newspaper its functions. And this loss of coherence is not made up for by the arrival of news from more distant and exotic places. The newspaper, in other words, is not a cure for the social conditions

which call it into being. It does put the world back together again in the shape of the small town.

Of course one did not need an elaborate argument like this in order to doubt the utopian visions of press and public which arose from the success of the penny papers. The idea of a "universal town meeting" could have been refuted simply by glancing at the pages of the daily newspaper, which, after all, did not seem to be addressed to informed citizens concerned about public affairs. There grew up therefore another vision, also in debt to the mass circulation newspaper-- the vision of the masses united not by the information they shared or the new sense of community they felt, but by the distractions they were provided, the emotions they were encouraged to vent in consuming the newspaper's diet of scandal and amusement. There grew up, in other words, the image of a mob, assembled not in physical space--although that, too, was a threat--but through the connecting power of mass communication. And the dangers this mob presented to republican government seemed more pronounced as the twentieth century approached. This darker vision of press and public is the subject of the next chapter.



PART TWO

THE PUBLIC AND THE PROFESSIONALIZED PRESS

## CHAPTER SIX

### THE IMPOSSIBLE PRESS

In this chapter we examine the drive to establish journalism as a profession in the early part of the twentieth century. The reason we are interested in the professionalization of journalism is that, in becoming a profession, the modern press had to declare its attitude toward the public. It had to say what its public responsibilities were and how it proposed to meet them. As we shall see, these declarations were made in an atmosphere of doubt and mistrust about the loyalty of the newspaper to any goal other than its own profits. What we want to know is, what kind of public did a modern press assume it was addressing, and what were the reasons for that assumption? As a way of framing that discussion, let us undertake a brief review of some of the concepts we have developed so far.

Prior to the growth of the press, public discussion always involved a physical location and face to face contact among citizens engaged in speech. For the Greeks this was all there was to "the public"-- a place where people talked and listened. It is only with the growth of the press that

we begin to conceive of a public that exists in some other way than through a physical gathering and that conducts its business through some other agency than face to face conversation. Thus we are obliged to ask whether this new public, wholly dependent on the press for its constitution, can exist in the same way as its classical predecessors. The only way to examine this question is to raise the issue of the public sphere or realm, the environment in which the public is presumed to gather and conduct its discourse.

In the eighteenth century, when most of our ideas about press and public were set down as principles, there existed a peculiar balance of conditions. On the one hand the press had been set free from direct censorship and was now able to circulate ideas among citizens, as well as bring word of what had happened in distant places. So the eighteenth century public realm had been enlarged and extended by the press, exactly as the framers of the Constitution had reasoned when they set down freedom of the press as a guaranteed right. On the other hand this press was a kind of subordinate to speech, a new medium kept in its place by the vitality of the old. The typical item in a newspaper of the day was a political or moral essay (or a reprinted speech) on, for example, "the rights of man." These pieces were not only meant to be discussed and debated, they arose from discussion and debate and returned there as soon as they were published. Today we are impressed by how many

readers an author like Tom Paine had (Postman 34). But perhaps this puts things the wrong way. All those readers were really the writers, in the sense that it was their discourse which Paine had simply put into a more dramatic and communicable form. Jefferson hesitated to claim authorship of the Declaration of Independence, believing it to be nothing more than a summary of what every citizen knew and had talked about, or as John Dewey described it, "an expression of the American mind so firm and plain as to command assent" (qtd. in Dewey, Living Thoughts 15)

Eighteenth century America enjoyed an extraordinarily vibrant public life, in which public discourses and the printed word supported and nourished one another.<sup>1</sup>

With print and speech, reading and conversing held in harmonious balance, with the scale of government small and oriented to the local community, and with the public realm anchored to a physical location like the coffee house or town hall, a vision of the press as the servant or enabler of public discourse was quite justified. Indeed, the connection was so obvious that governors routinely censored newspapers, fearing the effect they would have on public discussion and the political behavior of those participating in it. The fear was well founded. Neither the French nor American revolutions would have been possible without the spread of ideas and the relaying of news through the press. Because of this apparently natural "fit" between the press



and a vibrant public discourse, certain contradictory elements in the relationship tend to be obscured. These contradictions between a modern press and a vital, active public have been a recurrent theme in the present study. In general, we have argued that the conditions which enable the press to grow and mature are also those which undermine informed discussion among citizens of matters involving the common good.

#### Some features of the new public realm

The modern newspaper is a child of the city, according to Jefferson the very environment whose dimensions were certain to destroy the vigorous public life of the town. The scale of the city inhibits an on-going discussion among informed citizens involving matters of the common good.<sup>2</sup> As ways of gathering a public together, the town meeting and the modern newspaper arise from opposite social structures and lead to different public realms-- indeed, to different democracies. The main difference between the town meeting and the newspaper publics, between a community structure and a mass society, is that attention to the same issues or events, membership in a common world, preceeds the functions of the press up to the arrival of penny papers. The party press, for example, helped enlarge and give form to the political party, but it was always the servant of a cause larger than itself. The party paper "expressed" a unity of

sentiment, a common-ness that existed prior to the functions of the newspaper in gathering together an audience. As the party press declined and the newspaper grew more independent, the press ceased to be a representative of existing political structures and became more and more the means by which the polity was gathered together.

Today we see this in extreme form in the case of the national political conventions, where the party "meets" only to provide a scene for the television cameras, which are the true means for bringing people together politically.<sup>3</sup> The origin of this reversal of roles, where the medium becomes the political structure and politics an activity within it, is in the ability of the mass circulation newspaper to make its pages an area of organized attention, a new kind of public space reflecting the logic of mass communication, where citizens met up with events but not with each other. In this space people are brought together not to form themselves into groups, declare their common principles and discuss what action to take, but simply to find amusement and interest in the compendium of features the newspaper offers. With this development the press begins to constitute a new public realm, a public called into existence every morning according to the principles of the newspaper form. The result is that the press grows more and more independent from earlier political structures, especially the political party, for the area of permanently

organized attention has economic and political value which the press can exploit.

The new independence of the press was reflected not only in the absence of any direct party affiliation and the economic self-sufficiency of the mass circulation newspaper, but also in the ability of the press to determine how audiences were to be linked to leaders. After 1900, for example, the press stopped simply reprinting political speeches and began to write news stories about them, placing the speech in a larger context and inviting reaction from opponents or supporters of the speaker (Schudson, "The Politics of Narrative Form" 102-3). The speech, then, ceased to be the medium between the speech maker and the wider audience available through the press, and the press ceased to be dependent on the text of the speech as given. The functions of the speech were largely taken over by the news story, a form created by the press. It was through the newspaper that most people "heard" the speech. During the period when it simply reprinted speeches, the press functioned as an adjunct or extender of an earlier public event. But when it shifted to writing news accounts of speeches and inviting reaction, the press began to structure the event according to its own demands-- the demand for drama and conflict, for example, or the demand for brevity and consumability. Events, especially in the political sphere, then began to anticipate these requirements and

arrive pre-packaged as news.<sup>4</sup> This is what we mean when we say the press began to constitute the public realm: journalism replaces with forms of its own invention earlier means of linking leaders, followers and events. These forms are patterned after the demands of the newspaper, and later, television. Events then follow suit. The interview replaces the public address; the press conference replaces the town meeting; a television spectacle replaces the party convention; election campaigns pattern themselves after the demands of the evening news. Today terrorists take lives in order to manufacture events, the meaning of which is to gain media coverage.

#### Attention granted vs. attention gained

As assembled through the news the public realm is a very different universe of discourse from the town meeting or other traditional political structures, and the role of the press in constituting this new public realm is different from its role when it is merely the publicist or extender of traditional forms like the political speech. The main difference concerns what might be called the economics of attention. The content of the modern public realm often consists of the struggle to get and hold attention, while in a more traditional environment attention is a pact between speakers and audience, something that is given so that public discourse can have a content of its own. To



understand this difference we need merely compare the Lincoln-Douglass debates of 1860 with a typical election campaign today. Neil Postman has pointed to the extraordinary level of concentration the Lincoln-Douglass contests required on the part of the audience. The debates sometimes lasted as long as six hours, and yet they were popular events, drawing crowds in the thousands who listened, without benefit of amplification, to a form of speech that was more complex and linguistically dense than any an audience could tolerate today (44-51). In contrast, a typical campaign event in the 1980s has a single purpose in mind: to gain a few minutes of coverage on the evening news. What is said is hardly of any importance; the goal is to show the candidate in an attractive setting acting like a confident leader.

Now, all this would seem to be an effect of television, but the origins of the shift are actually much further back in journalism history. Today we are so accustomed to constant demands on our attention that it is hard to imagine what things were like before mass communication. Before the penny press, newspapers competed only in the sense that there were several to choose from in big cities. Readers subscribed; there were no street sales, no environment in which it was necessary to capture the attention of passing people. That is why the first page of the paper often contained long, dull advertising and small, dense type;

editors assumed that readers gave the newspaper their attention. But as soon as one penny paper started competing aggressively with another the situation changed. Now it was necessary to assume that readers could be won away by a competitor: attention had to be gained. The first page became the front page, a battleground for attention. Helen MacGill Hughes observed that

The front page would probably never have evolved from the first page were it not for the fact that purchase by annual subscription was largely replaced by single sales made by newsboys on the street to passers-by. But Benjamin Day sold the New York Sun on the street from the time of its founding; and from the outset the fact that the first page is on the outside, while the others are hidden from view, gave it peculiar importance. Then, as technique improved, the front page began to contrast with the first page in the same way as the scientific window-dressing of the department store contrasts with the non-descript display of the old drygoods emporium. The reader accepts the special characteristics of the front page as the nature of things, but they are all reducible to the editor's efforts to compel people to buy his paper and not another. (31)

The comparison between the front page and the department store window is apt.<sup>5</sup> Before mass merchandising, attention was not something a seller of goods had to produce. It was granted by a customer who was assumed to be interested (or not interested) in buying. But with the rise of department stores, mass advertising and the arts of display, attention became something to be won--one might almost say taken--from a busy and easily distracted consumer. If we consider the environment in which goods are presented for sale as a public realm, we can easily see the

shift that has occurred. Getting the customer's attention becomes in large part the content of the public realm created by the store. The space the store devotes to the attractive display of goods is a measure of how far this new public realm has advanced. In the case of the newspaper a similar measure is the size of the headline. As Hughes notes, large headlines are not a "natural" or inevitable feature of journalism. They arise from a certain environment, in which the competition for attention governs the behavior of communicators. Wherever these conditions prevail, the content of the public realm will be increasingly devoted to producing something that had once been a given, leaving less space, time and energy for all other activities. In a certain sense, then, content is eclipsed from public discourse: everything said is devoted to the struggle to be heard. More importantly, being heard becomes a matter of technique, in which proven strategies are recycled over and over, again emptying the content of public discourse.

To summarize the point we are making, in a traditional public realm--the Greek polis, the town meeting, the dry goods store before mass merchandising--attention is granted, while in the new public realm created by the mass media attention has to be gained. The result is a certain eclipse of the content of public life. People had once created the public realm among themselves by agreeing to grant attention

to a common cause or question, in the same way that people "create" the theatre by collectively agreeing to suspend disbelief. The show can then go on, the theatre can have a content, because the conditions creating the theatre have been secured. (What would the theatre would be like if actors, directors and playwrights thought that the audience might shift its attention at any moment to a competing spectacle? The answer is all too apparent: the theatre would be like network television. One could argue that this is exactly the direction the Broadway musical is taking.) By setting up a permanent and escalating competition for attention, mass communication institutionalizes the insecurity of the public realm: it may or may not exist, depending on whether people are listening. And there is always a competing event, a different headline, another store window to intensify the struggle.

#### Distractions from the problem of the public realm

The newspaper was the first agency to sponsor this struggle, and became, therefore, the originator of a vast change in the character of public life. And yet somehow it held on to its association with the classical public realm, a world in which discussion could go on as if the competition for attention had never pre-empted it. As we saw in the third chapter, it was assumed that a bigger, stronger, more profitable press would mean a more active and



informed public. But what in fact happens is that a bigger, stronger, more profitable press--based as it is on advertising revenue tied to circulation figures--creates a new climate for public affairs, in which attention has to be secured against a host of competitors, many of them coming from within the newspaper itself. Color comics begin to be popularized in the 1890s, just one of the many ways the newspaper seeks to attract attention to itself. The more it is concerned with producing attention to itself, the less of a role the newspaper can have in supporting the public realm, for the nature of the competition requires the newspaper to drag in anything that will shock, flatter or amuse. These contradictions between a modern press and a settled and secure public realm tend to be obscured by a pair of attitudes which need to be briefly examined. The first involves the important role the press has had in establishing the right of free speech, which tends to cloud the relation between the press and the fact of public discussion; the second involves the nature of information.

One of the ways the press has managed to identify itself with an ongoing communal discussion is through its long fight against censorship, in which it has functioned as the very embodiment of democratic principles, a faithful public servant always on the citizen against a threatening government. To this day the American press watches carefully over any threat of interference, partly to protect its

"turf" but also because defending against such threats puts the press in its most favorable, least ambiguous light: as the upholder of the principle of free discussion. Important as they are, controversies over freedom of the press give a narrow focus to the problem of public discussion. They suggest that what prevents the public from being fully informed and active in a democracy is the lack of information or the tainting of news through censorship, news management, restrictions on reporters and the like. Problems involving too much information, too much to be known, too little context, or the eclipse of content from public discourse--all of which the press may have exacerbated--are rarely visible through the smoke of First Amendment battles. When the emphasis is on the information necessary for public discussion to proceed, the existence and quality of that discussion tend to be taken for granted. The battle to "make public" suppressed facts thus tends to suppress the fact that the public itself has been transformed, with the press as one of the most important agents of the transformation.

The second factor obscuring the contradictions between a modern press and a traditional public involves a misunderstanding of the concept of information. There is a natural tendency to equate improvements in the gathering and distribution of news with a more informed public.<sup>6</sup> But as we argued in Chapter Two, the real question is whether the

growth of the press, in general, brings with it a growth of the conditions which enable people to use information as information. In addressing this question, it is not enough to focus on changes in the content of the press. The reason a content survey is not sufficient has to do with the nature of information. We are accustomed to thinking of information as a thing which can be packaged, distributed and consumed. From this perspective, it would be reasonable to look at the sort of information the press provides as a guide to whether it "informs the public." But as we have said several times, information is not really "in" the items which come over the wire and make their way into the newspaper. It is "in" the relations between people and a changing environment. The more changes matters, the more each fresh report makes a difference, the more information there can be in the news. That is why war is such a boon to journalism: war conditions create a context where even small changes in the status of events are meaningful to many people. Here we are not repeating the commonplace observation that information requires a context to be interpreted. We are saying much more. Information is context, in the sense that whether something "informs" or not depends on how meaningful a change in status is to a person receiving an item. Histories of the news are therefore incomplete when they focus on what the press has presented as news. A fuller history would be a history of

the "event" as a definer of current reality, a story of how recency came to be a way of understanding the world. This social history of the news, (a history of news "from the bottom," as it were) is as yet unwritten. Were it to be undertaken, it would have to focus on the social conditions which give recent events the authority to define the status of things; or, to put it more plainly, it would have to ask: what makes news matter?<sup>7</sup>

Critical inquiry into the press is today centered on a totally different question. Rather than wondering "what makes news matter?" press critics usually ask, "what is the matter with news?" The result is that the problems of accuracy and fairness dominate all other possible questions. As focal points for criticism, accuracy and fairness are hardly trivial matters, and it is quite reasonable for an open society to insist on such standards. (Whatever the problems with "objective journalism"--and there are many, both practical and theoretical--even a brief examination of what passes for news in totalitarian countries can be a convincing argument for objectivity as a principle.) What needs questioning is not the validity of accuracy and fairness as goals for the press, but the presumption that error and bias are all that prevents the press from "informing the public" and fulfilling its functions in a democratic society. It may be that a competent, complete and scrupulously fair press would still fail to "inform the



public" because of something in the nature of modern journalism and its relationship to its audience. That is the possibility we have been exploring in the present study.

#### The "golden age" of press criticism

With all of the above as a preamble, we can now begin to address the central issue of this chapter: the professionalization of the press and the attitude toward the public it implied. At the turn of the century in America the contradictions between a bigger and stronger press and a vibrant public realm were nearer to the surface than they seem today. As a public institution privately financed, the newspaper seemed to be at cross-purposes with itself. It continued to insist on its special place in a democratic society, and yet in its pursuit of profit it behaved no differently than any other business. Like any other business, it therefore became the target of the Progressive era's muckrakers and reformers. Press criticism filled the journals of the day; almost all of it began by recognizing that "journalism has now become a business."<sup>8</sup> Journalism had in fact become a business much sooner, at the point where the penny papers grew profitable; but the era of "Yellow Journalism" in the 1890s had put a sharper edge on the conflict between private profits and public duties, and gave a wider focus to questions of press performance.<sup>9</sup> Critics asked whether it was possible for mass circulation

newspapers to "inform the public," whether there might not be something in the way the modern newspaper was organized which prevented it from performing the functions democracy had assigned to it. The sort of the questions raised then concerned the structure of the press as an institution, and whether this structure was compatible with journalism's public functions.

What might be called a "golden age" of press criticism, stretching roughly the 1890s to the 1930s, coincided with the maturation of the newspaper as a commercial medium and with the rise of a self-conscious journalism profession. It also coincided with the Progressive era's preoccupation with the threat to public welfare posed by private businesses run solely for profit. Of course, as a business the press was a special case. Where most businesses could be regulated by an activist government concerned about "the public interest," the press enjoyed the special protection of the First Amendment. If it was to be improved, it would have to improve itself. And in a way it did, by becoming in the twentieth century a recognized profession with a set of standards designed to make the press a responsible public servant. Professional standards, then, were the solution put forward to the conflict between journalism as a business and journalism as an essential function in a democracy, a conflict which seemed especially sharp around the turn of the century. In the remainder of this chapter we examine

the attitude towards the public which professionalism implied. We will want to see how journalism as a profession faced the contradictions outlined earlier between a modern press and a secure and vibrant public realm.

The Progressive Era has been interpreted as an attempt to reconcile a familiar, village environment with a new, urban, industrial society whose dimensions overwhelmed inherited assumptions about economic order and political behavior. In simplest terms, it was a struggle with the bigness of things, a crisis of interpretation involving the scale of events in a technologically advanced era.<sup>10</sup> Obviously a full interpretation of that period is beyond the scope of the present study. Our interest is in how the central conflicts of the era--private profits vs. public interest, village environment vs. a modern, technological society--came to bear on the press, which had grown into a huge and profitable industry by the turn of the century. Our first task, then, is to describe the growth of the press from a successful experiment in commercial journalism in the 1830s to a big business in the twentieth century.

#### Newspaper growth 1870-1930

We have so far suggested that the modern newspaper is a direct outgrowth of the revolution in journalism brought by the penny press. This is most accurate at the conceptual level. The idea of human interest as a standard for

journalism, of news as a saleable commodity, of appealing to a wide audience and selling that audience to advertisers, of political independence backed by commercial success, of investing capital in a newsgathering network-- all these indeed began with the penny papers, especially Bennett's Herald. In that sense there can be no clearer dividing line than the 1830s. But to equate the penny press with the modern newspaper, as we have done so far, is misleading in so far as it suggests that there were no important changes after the 1830s. This is decidedly not the case. If it can fairly be said that the idea of the modern newspaper was born with the penny papers, then much of the working out of that idea--and of the contradictions inherent in it--occurred later, particularly in the period from the 1870s to the First World War.

The growth of the press is a complicated story, the results of which can rarely be explained in the language of cause and effect. More than most businesses, the newspaper is involved in almost every aspect of social growth and technological change. Most businesses make and sell a product, but the product the newspaper makes is of a different order of complexity. The newspaper sells the world to its readers at a loss, then turns around and sells its readers to the world at a profit. The complicating factor is the advertising function, which is itself a function of a developing consumer economy and also a



powerful factor in its development. Yet the ads are dependent on the news function. The two in tandem are capable of registering social change on any number of levels. Let us take one example of the newspaper as a complex social indicator. Stories about women activists appear in the news as women become more visible public actors in the Progressive era (A.M. Lee 396). The newspaper also begins to search for new features, such as advice columns, which will appeal to women, since women do most of the buying of the department store items advertised in the paper (A.M. Lee 587; Mott, American Journalism 507). This advertising naturally begins to address itself more to women in their new role as expert consumer (A.M. Lee 326). At the same time, evening and Sunday papers account for much of the growth of newspaper circulation from the 1870s on, in part because women readers prefer to take their paper then (Mott 599). Finally, woman increasingly make their way on to the newspaper staff for all of the above reasons (A.M. Lee 396; Mott 489-90). So, on at least five levels, in the content of its news coverage, in its formula for hooking readers, in the appeals of its advertisers, in its circulation patterns and in the composition of its staff, the newspaper "registers" the shifting status of women around the turn of the century and becomes itself an element in that shift.

The many levels of interaction between the newspaper and social change tend to frustrate any search for the cause

of newspaper growth. This is undoubtedly a reason for the emphasis on the "great man" approach in press history. It is much easier to attribute the fantastic growth of the press to the genius of the great publishers than it is to imagine the genius it would take to actually explain such a development. So a complete explanation for the growth of the press is at present lacking. But let us at least document that growth in more detail. There were 574 dailies in the United States in 1870, 971 in 1880, 1,610 in 1890, 2,226 in 1899 and 2,600 daily papers in 1909 (A.M. Lee 64-65). In 1860, the Herald led all papers in circulation with 77,000 (Mott 403). By 1900 the biggest papers were selling over a million copies a day (A.M. Lee 119). Following the Civil War newspapers grew at only a slightly higher rate than the population. But after 1880 the rate of growth climbs steadily upward, swamping the increases which followed the introduction of the penny press. Total circulation of all newspapers was 1.5 million in 1860, 2.6 million in 1870 and 3.6 million in 1880. It then begins to shoot upward, to 8.4 million in 1890, 15.1 million in 1900, 24.2 million in 1909 and 33.0 million by 1919. The number of papers sold per household rose modestly from .28 in 1860, to .34 in 1870 and .36 in 1880. Again, it then rises dramatically, to .66 in 1890, .94 in 1900, 1.23 in 1909, and 1.38 papers per family by 1919 (DeFleuer 65). Looked at another way, the number of people per daily paper sold fell

from 31.0 in 1850 to 2.9 in 1930 (A.M. Lee 70). Clearly, the reading of newspapers had become a national habit touching all classes in the twentieth century.

In New York, the figures on the popularity of newspapers are even more decisive. Before the penny press one paper was sold for every 14 or 15 inhabitants. The penny papers reduced this to one paper per 6.5 persons in 1840. The ratio was 1 to 3.9 in 1860, 1 to 2.3 in 1880 and 1.2 persons per paper sold in 1899. In 1929 there was more than one paper sold for every inhabitant in New York (A.M. Lee 80-81).

This tremendous expansion was financed by the growth of advertising. National advertising revenues for all publications rose from \$104 million in 1880 to \$256 million in 1900, \$540 million in 1909, \$1.4 billion in 1919 and almost \$3 billion in 1929 (Pope 25-6). More significant than these gross increases is the percentage of newspaper income derived from advertising. In 1879 44 percent of newspaper income came from advertising, the rest from sales to readers. By the turn of the century advertisements contributed more than half, and by 1909 they represented 64 percent of newspaper revenue. In 1929 the figure was 74 percent (A.M. Lee 749).

Larger circulations and bigger ad revenues go hand in hand, and one result is a tremendous increase in the amount of capital required to start or purchase a newspaper. Also

contributing to the demands for capital was the telegraph. The Associated Press was formed in 1849 to help offset high telegraph costs through a cooperative arrangement. Soon all newspapers either had to either secure a membership in the cooperative or spend large amounts of cash competing with it for news, both of which were expensive propositions. In 1835, Bennett started the Herald with \$500. In 1851, Henry Raymond and his associates had to invest \$69,000 to begin the New York Times (A.M. Lee 166). When Adolph Ochs purchased the Times in 1896 it was recapitalized at \$1 million (Mott 550). The Pittsburgh Press was sold in 1923 for \$6 million; Alfred McClung Lee reports that the purchasers had failed to exercise an option to buy the paper for \$51,000 in 1892. In the intervening years the newspaper had become a highly profitable, capital-intensive enterprise, leading Lee to observe in 1937 that, though publishers still profess belief in such "old-fashioned catchwords" as freedom of the press, they can afford to do so "largely because the price of chips defines the character and the number of those who can now play the journalistic game."<sup>11</sup>

#### The communication effects of cheap prices

While the costs of producing a newspaper rose, the price paid for a copy of the paper remained low and often fell. This is the reverse side of the increasing percentage of costs paid by advertising. One cent papers were common



from the 1830s right up to the First World War, a remarkable fact considering how expensive it had become to publish a newspaper. Competition, of course, was the mechanism by which the price of newspapers was kept down despite increased costs. Lee points to three different waves of sensationalism, one in the 1830s, another in the 1870s and 1880s, and a third after World War I when the tabloid war was at its height. In all three periods the same pattern shows itself. Prices creep up and the formula for the newspaper becomes fixed by custom until a competitor arrives to cut prices and deploy a new formula which draws readers who were either undiscovered or abandoned by the established press. The upstart paper begins to steal away advertising by the sheer size of its audience, forcing the established papers to cut prices and adopt the circulation-building features "discovered" by the competition. The period of intense competition ends with the erasing of differences between different classes of papers, all of which must adopt similar tactics to "keep up," and with the wiping out of smaller or weaker papers by the cheap prices of the survivors.<sup>12</sup>

Since a cut in prices will lead to higher ad revenues and big profits only when circulation is aggressively maximized, much of the cheap newspaper's energy goes into getting people to buy the paper. Cheap prices thus have more than an economic dimension to them. They have an

aesthetic, as well. The newspaper that "comes cheap," is not only inexpensive to purchase, it is made easier to read, more immediately likeable. It "comes cheap" in terms of effort. As publishers struggle to capture a portion of an increasingly volatile market, the reading act itself is transformed by all the attention paid to making it easier. Anything which will grab attention is preferred over anything which requires attention to grasp. The best example of this dynamic at work is the swelling in size of the newspaper headline, from a small category heading, to a terse announcement of recent events, to a screaming block of type so big, Mott reports, that in some headlines of the 1890s only five letters could fit across the page (American Journalism 544). Rather than headlines announcing events, events begin to be arranged to produce headlines: the bigger the better. This is literally the case with the popular crusades and circulation stunts that did so much to boost sales from the 1870s on. Newspapers financed attempts to reach the North Pole, sent balloons across the Atlantic and hired detectives to track down criminals, all for the purpose of creating more fantastic headlines (A.M. Lee 282-85; Emery 381). In 1896, William Randolph Hearst is said to have sent a cable to his illustrator in Havana who had complained about the lack of anything to illustrate. The cable read, "Please remain. You furnish the pictures and I'll furnish the war. Hearst." (Mott 529) The story

may be apocrophal, but the point it makes is accurate: the newspaper was in the business of producing attention to itself, and if that meant producing a war as a by-product, then this was entirely within the logic of a commercialized, competitive press.<sup>13</sup> Nor were these tactics confined to overtly sensational papers like Hearst's Journal and Pulitzer's World. In 1911, for example, the respectable New York Times sent a cable around the world to itself as a way of building interest in the paper. (The message<sup>14</sup> returned in 16 and a half minutes.)

The influence of advertising on the press is incompletely described by the newspaper's economic dependence on ads. The deeper influence was in the ethic of self-promotion, which made the production of attention the paramount goal, subordinating all other communication functions to that one. The penny papers had made the newspaper a vehicle for assembling attention to advertising. From the 1870s on, the newspaper became more and more a vehicle for assembling attention to itself as a medium for the ads. As Harold Innis once observed, the use of the front page to sell the newspaper amounts to the "indirect sale of advertising" through a news formula designed to create interest in the paper (The Press: A Neglected Factor in Economic History 23). In this context, Innis notes a remark by Ivy Lee, the pioneer of public relations, on the difference between news and advertising. News, said Lee,

is that which people are willing to pay to have brought to their attention; while advertising is that which the advertiser himself must pay to get to the people's attention. (Lee 13; qtd. in Innis 23)

Lee's view of news as anything people will pay to read expresses well the emphasis on attention alone which is the real effect of advertising on the press. But it leaves out an important complication: how much are people willing to pay? Through cheap prices and easier, more "naturally" interesting reading, the goal of the commercial newspaper was to insure that people never had to pay too much for their news. In fact, this is one way to define sensationalism: as that formula for news which requires readers to pay the least for their paper, both in terms of cents and sense-making, (that is, the effort or knowledge required to make sense of the world.) Today, we see this in extreme form with television news, which suggests that people can "get their news," not only for free, but with noticeably less mental effort than it takes to decode even a single page of the newspaper. As almost everyone knows, the substitution of "hard" news for items with proven attention-getting value, such as occurs routinely in local newscasts, is a direct result of the competition for ratings, which is required by the advertising-based structure of broadcasting, where the ads pay 100 percent of the costs. Broadcast news takes on a noticeably different character in England, where people pay more directly for



their television through a licensing fee. In a word, the news is more serious.

#### The attention producing machine

In general, the less people pay for their news, the more news is concerned entirely with getting their attention. The more (or the more directly) they pay, the more it is assumed that attention-fixing is a function performed by readers or viewers themselves. Thus, at the opposite extreme from the local newscast would be something like an oil industry newsletter, which is extremely expensive and puts almost no effort into making itself readable. The will to read is assumed to exist in purchasers of such a costly and specialized journal. But, as Pulitzer's biographer George Jurgens notes, the readers of a mass circulation newspaper in hot competition with its rivals "had to be persuaded to buy six mornings in the week, and six mornings in the week the readers of a rival newspaper could be won away" (48). Here the will to read is slight, investment is low and the effort to fix attention is assumed to be almost wholly the newspaper's responsibility. That effort thus becomes the content of the press, a development for which sensationalism is another name. Todd Gitlin reports that television executives assume the TV audience is uncommitted to what it is watching. "Industry lore," says Gitlin, assumes that "the audience is fickle and

expects instant clarity. The finger is always poised near the dial, so all salient elements have to be established with breathtaking haste" (161). The stereotyped characters and hackneyed plots that litter network television are thus a result of the need to immediately fix attention and maintain it at a breezy, undemanding pace. They can further be seen as the obverse side of the zero investment the audience makes in the content of television. Again, this is the almost inevitable result of an advertising-based structure; it is also one of the most vivid characteristics of a public realm constituted by media of communication.

The wholesale transfer of the attention-fixing function from individuals--in particular, from the individual reader--to the media of communication, where it becomes the formula for commercial success, is one of the most important effects of mass communication. Not only does it shape the messages of the mass media, it creates the environment in which all messages compete for attention.<sup>15</sup> Items that are easier to attend to get disproportionate "play" in the media, while those that cannot compete on the surface of attention remain unattended to. Here again, the USA Today is an interesting example. The Gannet Company has created a newspaper whose formula for news amounts to a single factor: readability. Everything which performs the attention-fixing function for people is considered news, while everything which requires people to fix attention by effort is to be

avoided. The editors thus insure that almost all news stories run on a single page, since the effort required to turn the page detracts from readability. The fact that a reasonably complete account of events might require another column of type is not considered relevant. What is underway here is an experiment with the act of reading analagous to the concern with "flow" in television broadcasting (Williams, Television: Technology and Cultural Form 86-118). The object is to remove from reading the continuous exertion of effort that has been the bane of schoolchildren since the advent of the book. In the Gannett Company's experiment, this aim is accompanied by an extensive market research program designed to produce inductively those features most easily read.<sup>16</sup>

We have tried to trace this process back to the economic basis of the mass circulation newspaper, in particular to the increased dependence on advertising revenue and the need to lower prices to boost circulation. The cheaper the price of each copy, the more the content of the press is concerned with selling more copies to make up for the loss in revenue from each sale. This is the source of the discontent with the press which reached a peak around the turn of the century: the newspaper had become an attention producing machine which really had no other goal. The historical irony is that, from the 1870s on, the machine grew so fantastically proficient, absorbing technology after

technology and reorganizing its internal structure so that by the First World War it had become an almost ideal embodiment of the industrial age, a highly integrated, tightly structured giant whose whirring presses, clacking wires and fast-talking reporters together performed a daily miracle of speed, power and timing.<sup>17</sup> Lincoln Steffens described a portion of this miracle in 1897:

The superintendent of delivery has to know exactly when he must have the first papers in order to catch the first mail; the foreman of the press-room must say how little time he needs to run off the first thousand copies; the foreman of the stereotyping room times his process to a second; and so on back to the news department, which has to be ready for the night editor's "make-up" in season to "go to press" at the moment determined by the closest reckoning of each chief of staff. ("The Business of a Newspaper" 463)

Together with the growth of the Associated Press, which put even the smallest paper in touch with all important events and the largest cities in touch with the smallest towns, the newspaper as a technology had been almost perfected by the 1890s. And yet the 1890s were also the period in which the excesses of sensationalism reached a peak with Hearst's Journal, Pulitzer's World and the many papers which imitated all or some of their tactics. "Yellow Journalism" coincided with the maturation of the press as a communication technology. The newspaper, a supreme accomplishment of the machine age, was at the same time the conductor of a trivial and debasing discourse, and, in the eyes of many, was more than ever a threat to the health of the community. How to interpret this fact?<sup>18</sup>



city a refuge for the artist and the deviant. In the city the special status of the stranger becomes generalized. He is no longer a visitor but a member, his presence is not an event but a condition of urban life. In Richard Sennett's clever phrasing, the city is a place "where strangers are likely to meet" (39).

With these conditions a new sort of "awayness" enters the character of daily life. People are now separated from one another not by physical space--they are more compressed than ever--but by a psycho-social distance that turns cohabitants into strangers. Events unfold at a distance that is not primarily spatial but mental: one is near to, but not aware of, all sorts of occurrences. Here, then, is an important paradox of city life: people and events are both distant and near. As Louis Wirth put it in a famous essay on urban living, "The contacts of the city may indeed be face to face, but they are nevertheless impersonal, superficial, transitory and segmental" (12). Thus the familiar modern lament: "alone in the crowd."

If personal isolation and physical closeness are ingredients for the urban angst, they are also the formula for a city newspaper. The complexity, fragmentation and incoherence of urban life create the need for news, while the nearness of the inhabitants to each other makes possible a central newsgathering operation and a distribution system that does not have to range too far to cover its territory.

Yellow journalism as a neutral technology

Edwin Emery, a contemporary historian of the press, sees yellow journalism as a problem in how the technology of the press was put to use. He writes:

The tools which were now available--linotypes and faster presses, more striking typography and layout, color printing, cartoons and photographs, skillful writing by larger staffs of reporters and editors, better communication facilities--all could be used constructively to build better newspapers. Stories which were written in a more readable style, or which in their nature appealed to the human interests of readers, could increase popular acceptance of the newspaper without detracting from its social usefulness. Bigger headlines, pictures, blobs of color might give the newspaper a new face, and might cause some readers to grimace at the result and yearn for the bygone days; but effectively used, these devices too could be useful and desirable.

Of course, these new tools could also be used irresponsibly, Emery observes. The newspaper could place "success in snaring readers ahead of the primary obligations of journalism." This is what yellow journalism was: the new, technologically-advanced journalism "without a soul." The shameless purveyors of the yellow press were those who "seized upon the techniques of writing, illustrating, and printing which were the pride of the new journalism and turned them to perverted uses." Pulitzer, in Emery's view, "had opened Pandora's box" by perfecting the devices of sensationalism. His discoveries were then taken up by other, less scrupulous publishers who "did not understand that Pulitzer had sought to achieve a balance between

informing the reader and entertaining him" (415-16).

The rhetorical problem Emery is tackling is to reconcile the newspaper's power as a communication technology with its debasement as a social instrument. His solution is notable in two respects. First, he sees as "neutral" not only the physical instruments of the modern press, the wires and presses, but also the symbolic forms the press had developed to capture attention and maximize circulation: the human interest story, the splashy headline, the sensational twist on a story. These devices have no effects themselves, he says; their meaning lies in how they are used. That the headline itself may have a bias, that attention-getting as an industrial art may have an effect on the things attended to, that readability may have an ideological dimension to it, in short, that the "interesting" may serve some interests and undermine others-- these possibilities escape Emery's view of the modern newspaper as essentially a neutral instrument.

The remarkable thing, however--and this is our second comment on Emery--is that many observers at the time of the yellow press did not share his view that the modern newspaper was a neutral technology somehow perverted by unscrupulous publishers. Rather, they saw it as inevitably biased by its commercial basis. "Journalism has become a business" was for these observers an ominous and deeply significant development. For it meant that the newspaper,

by its nature, would have a duty to private profits first and that its public functions would inevitably suffer. In 1903 the Nation called it a "commonplace" that publishers are "far more concerned today with the sums which can be made out of their properties than with the opportunities they may have to enunciate political principles or insist upon high ethical standards in our national life"

("Education and Journalism" 168). The long and storied equation between the press and the spread of political thought seemed to have lost its relevance. The goal of the modern newspaper was simply to make and sell a product. That the sacred functions of the press had been profaned by commercial success was certainly on the mind of the critic who observed in 1893 that the "fundamental principle of metropolitan journalism today is to buy white paper at three cents a pound and sell it a ten cents a pound."<sup>19</sup>

Much of the concern about journalism as a business focused somewhat simple-mindedly on the direct influence advertisers and big corporations had in shaping the news.<sup>20</sup> While there was no lack of incidents to justify such complaints, the deeper effects of journalism as a business did not require such obvious interference by capital in the news. This point did not go unnoticed at the time. A 1902 Atlantic article on "The Newspaper Industry" noted that the popular newspaper undermines intelligent public discourse by advocating contradictory things at top volume. The typical



yellow journal "shrieks so continually," on so many different subjects and "so obviously without sincerity, that it can lead in no particular direction," the writer observed. The result is a kind of ideological chaos which does not encourage "lucid reflection on political programmes in the popular mind." Emery might blame such an effect on the publisher's lack of principles, but the Atlantic saw it as an inevitable outcome of the newspaper's overwhelming need to "attract attention thus to itself."<sup>21</sup> In other words, the confusion of the public mind was a logical result of the way the newspaper was organized. The only way to improve public discourse would be to change the structure of the press. Thus, the Atlantic's solution: "public opinion will have to turn to the weekly press," where the monetary investment is lower and discourse can therefore take a more considered form (Fisher 751). This sort of suggestion was not unique. Around the turn of the century there were proposals for an endowed newspaper, talk of a municipal newspaper, and an attempt by E.W. Scripps to market an "adless" daily, (the experiment failed in 1917).<sup>22</sup> These proposals show how convinced many observers were that it was the structure of a commercialized press that stood in the way of its public duties, not the scruples of particular journalists.

From structural conflict to professional conduct

How is it possible for writers at the time to have seen the structural factors preventing the press from fulfilling its public functions, while Emery, writing in 1972, views the matter as simply a problem in the personal integrity of publishers? Why is it that many critics of the press around the turn of the century could see that what Emery calls "success in snaring readers" had become "the primary function of journalism," whereas for Emery, a historian, the former is logically opposed to the latter? What accounts for this naivete about a period which was hardly naive about itself? <sup>23</sup> Let us see if we can answer some of these questions. Emery's views on the yellow press place him solidly within the tradition of what James Carey has called the "whig interpretation of journalism history," which, according to Carey,

views journalism history as the slow, steady expansion of freedom and knowledge from the political press to the commercial press, the setbacks into sensationalism and yellow journalism, the forward thrust into muckraking and social responsibility. ("The Problem of Journalism History" 4)

The whig interpretation looks at newspaper history and sees continuous improvement in press freedom and the journalist's sense of public duty. It tells a certain story about the rise of the modern press. According to this tale, the newspaper first freed itself from political dependence

by becoming commercially successful; journalists then freed themselves from the excesses of commercialism by developing codes of conduct which emphasize a commitment to truth,<sup>24</sup> fairness, and the public's right to know. This is what is meant by professionalism in the press. James Curran has described essentially the same reflex in English press history. There are generally thought to be three stages in the development of the press in England, he notes. First, a period of direct control by the state in which censorship is routine, second, the drive toward independence based on the newspaper's increasing success as a business, and, in the twentieth century, a third stage in which "the press becomes less partisan and more socially responsible due to the growing commitment amongst publishers and journalists to the professional goals of objectivity, balance and accuracy" (51).

For the present study, the most important effect of the whig interpretation of history is to frame the conflict between private profits and public functions as a problem in professional conduct rather than a structural tension inherent in the organization of modern journalism. Herbert Birkhead, in an unpublished dissertation examining the "professional project" in journalism, argues that the whig approach to press history was developed by writers ideologically committed to the profession of journalism and to journalism education as training for the profession.

These writers developed a "textbook tradition" of historiography, where history is useful as a way of bringing students into the fold and giving them a sense of confidence about their chosen field.<sup>25</sup> The textbook tradition, he says, is

an interpretation of journalism history consistent with the role of professional journalism education, a function that intersects with and supports a broader professional model of the press as a social institution. (xvii)

The "professional model" of the press originated, Birkhead argues, in the turn of the century conflict between the technological might of a modern press and its nakedly commercial motives. Two interpretations of the press emerged, he says. One emphasized "the speed, range and scale of modern journalism as social benefits," while the other stressed journalism's "emerging corporate structure" along with its commercial bias. Professionalism unfolded as a way of rescuing the communication power of newspaper technology from the economic structure which made that technology possible. The professional journalist, it was asserted, would be an efficient expert putting the machinery of the press to socially useful ends, and he could do this even while housed within a business dedicated like any other to monopolizing a market and making a profit. As long as he held to his professional standards, the modern journalist could fulfill the classical functions of the press despite the transformation of journalism into a business and the peddling of news as a commodity. Birkhead writes:



Advancing a professional claim based on a compelling technological transformation of the press worked toward legitimizing the economic aspects of a fundamentally altered press. Indeed, the claim helped to assert that the nature of the communications revolution was more technological than economic. (61)

Emery's view of yellow journalism as a set of basically sound techniques put to unscrupulous uses is an example of the "professional project" at work. Again, the goal of this project is to reframe structural conflicts as matters of professional conduct. Thus, Pulitzer, for Emery a man of careful scruples, "sought to achieve a balance between informing the reader and entertaining him." Pulitzer's professional standards help contain and balance (and ultimately make harmless) the conflict between attention-getting and information. His unprofessional imitators, however, "perverted" the technology of the press, tipping the scales toward a socially harmful result. The tools of journalism, including the art of arresting attention, remain neutral devices, no more powerful in determining the message of the press than a typewriter is in shaping the text that is typed on it. The improvement of journalism, therefore, does not involve the drastic step of restructuring the market-based economy of the newspaper. Rather, it simply requires a professional awareness on the part of the practitioner, who holds in his hands the power to make journalism a force for good or ill.

Was journalism a profession?

The difficulty for those who put forward this interpretation of the press was that journalism shared almost none of the features of the established professions such as law or medicine, where the claim to be upholding professional standards was backed by the economic independence of the practitioner. A doctor or lawyer owned his own practice and received a fee directly from a client who needed his expert services. In the era of journalist-as-enterprising-printer or journalist-as-publisher-and-editor, those who constituted the press enjoyed a similar status: they ran their own shop. But in a modern newspaper organized as a bureaucracy this was clearly not the case. As the Nation noted in 1873, in the newspaper industry there was no longer any way for "the laborer to climb into the position of the capitalist" ("The Profession of Journalism" 38). The modern journalist was housed somewhat charitably within a business he neither owned nor controlled, and his "fee" came not from those who supposedly needed his services--that is, members of the public--but from publishers supported by advertisers who sold goods to consumers. All three of these groups were in a sense "clients" of the journalist, yet he was not in a position to dictate to any of them just what services they required, another aspect of a profession which journalism

lacked.<sup>26</sup> Nor did the journalist command any esoteric knowledge a laymen could not understand. Indeed, it was the business of the press to deal in a language the average person could understand, which made it difficult for the journalist to surround his craft with anything resembling a professional mystique.<sup>27</sup> The absence of any esoteric body of knowledge also made professional training difficult, and prevented the press from licensing its members or controlling the number of people who entered the profession. "There are altogether too many people who call themselves 'journalists' for no sound reason," complained one writer in 1910 (Hamilton 650). The trouble was, what sound reasons were there? As M. de Blowitz wrote in 1893,

...by dissection of the dead human body may be discovered the laws of medicine, and the best methods of curing the living; a lawyer may learn in the schools the instruments and conditions of his profession, namely civil laws and the methods of court procedure; the art of the orator has its teachable maxims and principles; the art of war its rules and precepts; indeed, throughout the entire list of human professions, there is for each a special series of laws and conditions by knowledge of which he who enters as an apprentice may go out, by slow degrees of advancement, a master. But in journalism, alone among the professions, this is not the case. In this career, there is no body of doctrine, no series of fixed rules, apparently no possible method of instruction... (38).

Of course, these difficulties did not prevent journalism schools from opening beginning in 1908.<sup>28</sup> The idea of a professional training ground for journalists was given its biggest boost by Joseph Pulitzer, who proposed in

paper, capable of headlines like "Blood on a Mother's Lips" (Juergens 41). Especially in its battles with Hearst's Journal in the 1890s, it was decidedly jingoistic and anti-intellectual, reflecting, no doubt, the prejudices of its readers and just as certainly profiting by them (Juergens 210-233). Equally fierce in exploiting the common man's credulity and fighting for the common good, Pulitzer was both a boon and a menace to public welfare, as he himself may have realized. A proud man, he did not always live up to his own standards; he regretted having competed with Hearst at such a debased level (Juergens 45).

#### The lost power base of the press

Steffens's point was this: if Pulitzer could not find a way to employ an entirely "responsible" journalist or, indeed, to become one himself, he could at least create a school dedicated to the standards he could imagine but not meet. And that is what the College of Journalism was to be: a haven for "responsible" journalism, and, more importantly, a haven from the realities of the marketplace. "The school of journalism is to be not only not commercial, but anti-commercial," Pulitzer wrote in an article defending his idea in the North American Review. "It is to exalt principle, knowledge, culture, at the expense of business if need be. It is to set up ideals, to keep the counting room in its proper place, and to make the soul of the editor the



soul of the paper" (655). The goal was to create an environment where journalism would be exclusively a public affair, where the "principles of journalism" would be studied apart from the industrial setting in which they were practiced (656). Pulitzer said that he hoped to "create a class distinction between the fit and the unfit" in the press, a distinction "based not upon money, but upon morals, education and character" (649).

The emphasis on character was of the highest importance. The word is found again and again in discussions of journalism as a profession (Harger 224; Hamilton 648-9). The school of journalism was to instill character in young men, who would then be able to resist the pressures of commercialism. There was nothing wrong with the newspaper being a business, Pulitzer thought. After all, the more profitable the paper, the more certain its independence, and the less vulnerable it would be to corruption. The problem was not business, but the spread of its values to realms where they did not belong. Commercialism, he said, "becomes a degradation and a danger when it invades the editorial rooms" (659). The way to prevent this invasion of editorial territory was to produce journalists of such fine moral character that they would not allow the line to be crossed.

The editor, the real "journalist" of the future, must be a man of such known integrity that he will be above the suspicion of writing or editing against his convictions. He must be known as one who would

resign rather than sacrifice his principles to any business interest. It would be well if the editor of every newspaper were also its proprietor, but every editor can at least be the proprietor of himself. If he cannot keep the paper from degrading itself, he can refuse to be a party to the degradation. (660)

Let us be clear about the role integrity is asked to play in a professionalized press. At an earlier stage in press history, "the journalist" as a cultural figure was represented by the great editor who was also, as Pulitzer says, "a proprietor." Bennett, Dana, Greeley, Raymond, Bowles, Godkin, Hearst and Pulitzer himself were all embodiments of the press as an institution. These men gained their authority because they had bold ideas and powerful platforms from which to launch them. Of course, the ability to publish a profitable newspaper did not automatically confer wisdom on the publisher. As one Atlantic writer observed in 1902, the nineteenth century editor was often absurdly impressed with himself and his visions. A heroic figure in some respects, he was quite comic in others. But whatever his excesses--and they were legion--the editor who used his paper as a personal platform stood for "a noble ideal," said the Atlantic: that the press had a civic duty to be a leader of public opinion (Fisher 747-8). Through his functions in shaping and giving voice to popular opinion, the great editor was "associated with the statesman in the affairs of government," and had a similar, if not equivalent, standing in the community. This

was the original incarnation of the professional journalist: the man who attempted to lead through the newspaper he owned. That he also made money from the enterprise no doubt helped his standing, but it was not the reason for it. Journalism used to be a profession, the Atlantic reasoned, when "not business prestige, not commercial success, but intellectual abilities and moral qualities, gave it its force and vitality" (746).<sup>29</sup>

The same point has been made about the British press by a contemporary observer. According to Philip Elliot, the original "professional" journalists in England were editors who used their papers as power bases to build reputations and gain political clout. In the nineteenth century there was a "brief hiatus," he says, "between censorship, corruption and economic controls and the commercialization associated with publishers for a mass audience." This period produced a "myth of professionalism," in which "the great writing editors appear as a force in the land beholden neither to their masters nor their readers" (173).

The twentieth century meaning of professionalism arose from the realignment of power within the newspaper. Rather than hiring capital, the modern editor was hired by capital, and his job was to produce a paper that would sell enough copies to gain advertising revenue. As an employee dependent on the business side of the paper the journalist had no power base; the newspaper was no longer a platform he

owned and controlled. Professionalism was put forward as a way of restoring the independence and prestige lost to the journalist when the newspaper was transformed into a business. Independence and prestige were once a function of the powerful position the newspaper held in the community. As the publisher of a widely distributed paper, the great editor was a force to be reckoned with. He gained respect when he learned how to use that force for purposes other than making money. But in the new arrangement the independence and prestige of the journalist had to be guaranteed in some other way. Lacking control over the newspaper as a social instrument, the journalist had to find a way of resisting the pressures of commercialism and gaining stature in the public eye. Thus the emphasis on personal integrity. The professional journalist would not allow the news to be tainted because to do so would violate his deep sense of public duty. With this incorruptability he could gain a reputation as a force to be reckoned with, using, if necessary, the one power he did have: the threat of resignation. As Pulitzer said, "He must be known as one who would resign rather than sacrifice his principles to any business interest.... If he cannot keep the paper from degrading itself, he can refuse to be a party to the degradation" (660).



Separating the press from the newspaper

The school of journalism was to aid in the training of character by preaching a sharp division between the editorial and business functions of the press. In developing his plan for the school, Pulitzer enlisted the advice of Charles Elliot, President of Harvard and probably the most respected figure in higher education at the time. Among Elliot's recommendations was a course in "Ethics of Journalism," which would educate students in the proper relations among publishers, editors and reporters, paying special attention to the journalist's freedom of thought and the role of the publisher in shaping the presentation of news (Kimball, "The Profession of Publicist" 804). As an example of the "professional training" that might be given to journalists, this course had an interesting object. For its very existence was an admission that the independence of the journalist was imperiled by the structure of the modern newspaper. If the profession of journalism could not offer its recruits the actual independence that comes from running one's own shop, it could at least train them in how not to be compromised by a compromising situation. To put it another way, if freedom of the press, as A.J. Liebling said, belonged to those who own one, the professional journalist, unable to own a press, could at least secure a kind of intramural freedom by drawing a line inside the newspaper

offices across which the owners of the press--those with the real freedom--were not allowed to go. The professional journalist would then be the expert in maintaining the line's integrity, and thus his own. In this fashion the very conditions preventing journalism from becoming a true profession are converted into problems about which the journalist has expert knowledge-- if he is professionally trained. Dependence is transformed into independence, not by altering the journalist's basic predicament but by training him in how to prevent it from becoming worse.

Pulitzer's proposal was generally well received, (Baker 39) but there were a significant number of critics. That the journalism school faced an impossible task was clear to several writers around the turn of the century. In a reply to Pulitzer in the North American Review Horace White observed that the university has nothing to teach journalists since the field requires no special skills that can be learned in a classroom (26). The best that could be hoped for, he said, is to produce the kind of man "we have in mind when we say Mr. So-and-So is a gentleman and a scholar." But this type, a generally educated person, is the goal of the university as a whole, not the province of any special school, White argued (27). Furthermore, even if a journalism school could succeed in producing an educated man, where is the demand for his intelligence and sound judgment? With yellow journalism near its height and

showing no signs of abating, the field offers little opportunity for the kind of journalist the school seeks to train. White wrote,

No self-respecting youth will prepare himself for future connection with a yellow journal; and, in general, the number who will prepare for newspaper work will be governed by the aspect in which journalism daily presents itself to their eyes. What are the most prominent features of journalism today? They are pictures, head-lines, color scheme, job type, sports, gossip. Is it any wonder that the bright young men, those who feel "growing pains" for high achievement and growing hope for distinction therein, are repelled from a profession which presents itself in such harlequin garb? (32)

Arthur Reed Kimball covered many of the same points in a 1903 piece on "The Profession of Publicist." The "conditions of modern journalism afford only occasional opportunity for independent work, such as is afforded in other professions," Kimball wrote. "Only by happy chance of a broad-minded and high-minded" owner, or by "the rarer chance of being himself admitted to a share in the ownership" can a journalist, no matter how well trained, "enjoy that degree of independence which is the distinguishing mark of professional life." Nor is the pay particularly high in journalism, Kimball noted; and professional training shows no signs of increasing it. While a capacity to "grasp great issues and the wit to express great thoughts," might conceivably bring a certain prestige to the journalist, these are the skills least necessary for success in the field and the least esteemed by

employers. And yet the same skills--so little in demand--are "those which first of all a school of journalism is founded to develop in so far as it is to realize its purpose of training young men to be publicists, and thus of raising the profession of journalism" (807-810). The real problem in making journalism a profession, Kimball said, is that, compared to the editor who was also a proprietor, the modern journalist "has, and can have, no right except to resign." Under these conditions, he concluded, "it is futile to attempt through a special school to raise journalism to the rank of a profession," for

journalism must increasingly repel the men to whom naturally it would most appeal, the men to whom it owes the largest share of its influence in the past, the men to whom it should look to give it character in the future. (810-11)

This fairly well summarizes the point we have been making about the school of journalism: that it attempted to set up a world apart from the realities of the marketplace, a world in which the journalist would once again enjoy his independence and prestige despite the disappearance of the conditions which had once guaranteed it. Part of what we mean by a "world apart" is that the journalism school would be a haven from commercial pressures where no attention was paid to the business aspects of journalism. But that is not all. The goal was also to create a separate world within the newspaper, to divide the editorial functions from the advertising and circulation departments, and to give a



sacred meaning to the line between them. On the integrity of this line would be built the reputation of the press as a responsible public servant. As long as reporters and editors could be said to brook no interference in the news by those primarily concerned with business, the press could separate itself as an institution from the newspaper as an industry-- indeed, from industry in general. The wall separating the editorial and business departments could then take on a deeper meaning. It could help divide public life in general from the pursuit of private profits, in effect protecting democracy from any threat posed by industrial capitalism. A press that functioned strictly as a public servant implied a public that demanded strictly a responsible press, and this implication remained whether or not such a public existed or could exist in an age of mass communication. In this fashion the press began to distinguish itself from the whole problem of the modern public realm, from an increasingly competitive symbolic environment in which attention was no longer granted but gained.

#### The creation of an impossible press

Part of the goal of professionalism, then, was to set up a "world apart" from the conditions of an industrial society, a world in which public discussion was still vibrant and meaningful and the public itself took an active

role in politics through the agency of the press. This movement toward a mythical public realm originated at precisely the point where certain illusions about democracy and capitalism, the newspaper and business, could no longer hold. While the newspaper was still under the direction of the great editor, the contradictions inherent in its growth were overshadowed by the heroic efforts of the men who guided it. In the nineteenth century it was still possible to believe in the newspaper as a source of enlightenment and a leader of public opinion (Birkhead 72-73). But as the twentieth century neared the great editor seemed more and more a menace to public welfare. In the 1890s Hearst and Pulitzer found themselves pushing sensationalism to its limits, not because they were totally without scruples, but because the logic of their battle for bigger circulations forced them to employ the full resources of the newspaper toward a single goal: the production of attention. Yellow Journalism was not an original formula. What Hearst and Pulitzer did was turn the potential of the modern newspaper loose, reducing all its possible functions to one, primary function: grabbing attention. The threat this posed to democratic traditions was obvious. At the same time a larger threat was unfolding, that of the giant corporation manipulating events in its own interest, (the dominant theme of the Progressive era.) At just this moment, when the newspaper had exposed itself as a public menace and the lust

for profit seemed to threaten the foundations of democracy, the press began to create its world apart from industrial society, one in which the strict adherence to professional standards would guarantee the status of the press as a public servant. An impossible press was born, one which sought to solve the whole problem of public life simply by controlling the conduct of journalists.

Around the turn of the century there were many doubted that this would be enough. A 1903 editorial in the Nation on "Education in Journalism" made the simple point that it would do no good to uplift the standards of journalists when it was clearly the tastes of readers which determined the content of newspapers. "It might almost be said that it is the newspaper-reader who needs to go to school, and not the newspaper maker," the Nation observed (168). From this point of view, it is the economic structure of the press and the role of the reader in that structure that determine whether journalism can realize its high-minded ideals, not the temper or training of journalists. This was also the conclusion come to by an anonymous journalist in a 1925 piece in Harper's. The writer took the time to muse on an important irony we have already mentioned, the trivial uses to which the noble power of the press was being put.

I turn to our mechanically and professionally sophisticated forty-four pages and find that yesterday the most important happening on earth was that a foreign resident shot a fellow alien, probably fatally, for alleged independent advances to the former's ten year-old daughter. I find that Jack Dempsey has married Miss Taylor; that Floyd Collins's

body in its Kentucky cave is not yet reached; that a French jury has acquitted an actress who killed her lover to spare him his "death agony"; that a woman who has presided over the Nebraska house of representatives for one day (not a word of what she or the house did is published); and that gifts donated to a prophetess of a non-forthcoming end of the world by her followers will not be restored by the courts to the givers.

So much for page one!... (4)

The author's solution to the problem was an interesting one. A few established papers, using the same aggressive tactics developed to sell papers, must attempt to "sell" the people on the sort of news that is "worth an intelligent citizen's attention," in defiance of the apparent fact that there is no popular demand for such news. It may be, the journalist speculates, that there is more of a demand than previously thought. On the other hand, it may also be that "the American mass intellect" has sunk so low that no remedy is possible. He then concludes that "it is time we learned this definitely." Even journalists, he says, "have a moral right to know whether in the future their profession is to afford honorable employment for gentlemen of intellect and independent judgment." Newspapermen are as entitled as anyone else to their self-respect, or at least to a conclusive answer on whether such respect is possible (7).

Here is another view of the press at odds with the professional attitude. In demanding an unambiguous answer to the question, "what sort of public is out there?" the author was declaring that professional status depends on the



relations established between readers and writers. If those relations are founded on mutual respect, the journalist can take pride in himself as a professional. But if respect for the public proves unfounded, then this reflects poorly not only on the popular intellect, but on the journalist who must cater to it. Journalism can rise no higher than the mind of its audience, and since this must be the case, it is time to learn conclusively what the nature of that mind is.

Now this is a provocative question, unsettling not only to the professional project in journalism but, indeed, to the foundations of democracy. As John Dewey once put it, democracy is upheld "not merely by faith in human nature in general but by faith in the capacity of human beings for intelligent judgment and action if proper conditions are furnished" ("Creative Democracy: The Task Before Us" 224). By proposing that the press furnish the "proper conditions" and await a verdict, the journalist in Harper's was demanding an answer to a question that has rarely concerned anyone inside or outside the press. That question is: is it possible to inform a modern public? The answer the profession of journalism has implicitly put forward is, "yes, if the information presented is accurate and objective," in other words, if professional standards are met.

### Professionalism as ideology

What exactly is wrong or misleading about this answer? Let us see if we can clarify the point by risking an analogy with the medical profession. Imagine for a moment that the most important factors affecting the health of the population are more or less environmental. The air we breathe, the water we drink, the food we eat, the atmosphere we work in, the kind of life we are encouraged to lead in a technologically advanced age-- suppose these are the things which make people sick. The medical profession would then be presented with a problem. It has the responsibility of making people well, and yet the factors making them sick are much larger than the resources of the profession. A question therefore arises: at what level should the medical profession fix its responsibilities for health care? Is its job to cure disease? Should it also attempt to change the way its patients lead their lives in order to prevent disease? Or should it try to change the society so that the conditions causing illness are corrected? It is possible to operate at any of these levels--the personal, the social, the political--and still be "responsibile," depending on how one's responsibilities are defined. The medical profession, in other words, could easily set up a "world apart" from the most important factors in health and disease, and yet operate responsibly within that world, especially if it

determines its own standards and judges the conduct of its own members. It can be argued that organized medicine has done just that by historically neglecting nutrition and preventative care generally in favor of an emphasis on surgery and drugs. And yet this does not mean that surgeons have acted unprofessionally. The problem concerns the way the profession has defined itself. Professional standards, then, have a dual function. On the one hand they inspire public confidence by setting up codes of conduct and some form of punishment for violators; on the other hand they fix an outer limit on professional responsibility, defining that portion of the problem the profession will treat as real. This is one way in which professionalism becomes an ideology: the profession is given the power to define what does and does not constitute a breach of public duty. That which is defined away may in fact constitute the bulk of the problem the profession claims to be treating.

Now, without stretching the comparison too far, let us view the press as a profession with responsibility for the health of the body politic. This is certainly claiming no more for the press than the press has often claimed for itself. Pulitzer, for example, said that in endowing a college of journalism he had in mind not the elevation of the profession but "the welfare of the Republic" (678). The question is, at what level will the press assume its duty to the health of the Republic? Will it take a broad view of

the problem and consider the domain of journalism to be the whole of public life, or will it somehow narrow its focus to something simpler? The professionalization of the press needs to be viewed as an answer to this question, a fixing of the outer limit of journalism's responsibilities. As codes of conduct, professional standards tend to focus attention inside the area defined as real by the profession, while their most important effect is often to leave out, deny and otherwise define away everything that lies outside the profession's view of itself. This is what the Nation had grasped in saying that readers were the ones who ought to go to school; the idea of professional training for journalists implicitly denied the role of the reader in shaping the character of the press. It sought to focus attention instead on the character and qualifications of journalists, an area over which the profession of journalism could more easily exert control. This sort of willful blindness to the predicament of the press was part of the journalism school from the beginning. As we have seen, Pulitzer deliberately sought to preach the "principles of journalism" apart from the industrial setting in which the work of the press actually took place. He realized that for the journalism school to "raise the standing of the editorial profession," its goal must be to

mark the distinction between real journalists and men who do a kind of newspaper work that requires neither culture nor conviction, but merely business training. (656-7).



Note that the "real journalists" are those the profession considers to be "really" doing the work of journalism, while those who are "not really" journalists do some "other kind of newspaper work" defined as other by the profession. With this sort of strategy the press began to separate itself as an institution from the newspaper as a commercial medium, the goal being to improve the prestige of the profession by leaving behind, defining as "other," that portion of the newspaper which was involved in producing and selling attention as a commodity. This was the explicit theme of M. de Blowitz's 1893 article on "Journalism as a Profession." The goal of professional training should be to create a special type, "standing head and shoulders above the stream of contemporary journalists," de Blowitz wrote (42). By recruiting talented people into the journalism school the

level of the profession can be raised, not only from the point of view of the work produced, but also in the intrinsic value and dignity of the producers; thus banishing forever those who are the bane of the profession, the pirates and footpads of the highway, lured thither by misery or chance, who arm themselves with a pen as a revolver, and who, sheltered behind the columns of a paper as behind trees of a forest, have made in certain countries the name of journalist synonymous with an insult or a calumny (45).

Of course, there was a problem with this strategy. Those who were "the bane of the profession" also did the work of attracting readers. Leaving them behind meant leaving the popular newspaper behind, which threatened to

strand the professional journalist without an audience. After all, the horrors of sensationalism were at least in part a reflection of what readers were demanding of the press. If a professionalized press sought to separate itself from the means by which attention was gained, from the business of buying and selling readers, it was implicitly claiming that it wanted nothing to do with the mass audience. This was alright for a profession which consciously addressed itself to an elite, as newspapers had before the penny papers. But the claim the journalist made for professional status was based on the solemn duty he owed to the general public. He might be paid by the publisher, but his allegiance was to the people.

#### Dismissing the public in the name of the public

At the time this claim was being put forward, yellow journalism was providing ample evidence that readers of the press wanted nothing more than distraction and amusement. The "people" seemed to be composed of crude, ignorant masses who wanted to see their own prejudices reflected in the pages of the newspaper. So where was this public whose interests a professionalized press was dedicated to serving? What was the evidence for its existence? The press could find no answer to these questions, and yet some way had to be found to avoid identification with the demonstrated readership of the newspaper. For its tastes only led back

to the dirty business of buying, selling and struggling for attention, a world from which professionalism was a deliberate escape. The professionalization of the press, then, was a dismissal of the actual public journalists faced. In its stead was placed a mythical public formed in the image of the journalist's professional standards, the public that would have to exist if the claims of the press to professional status were to make any sense. This is part of what the "public" became in the discourse of modern journalism, an imagined body to which a scrupulous press owed a sacred duty.<sup>30</sup> To put it as simply as possible, the press needed to invent the public as an ideal reader when it separated itself from the actual readership of the newspaper.

Michael Schudson conducts a related argument about the professions and the public in Discovering the News. Early in the twentieth century, he says, public opinion began to mean something new. In the nineteenth century it had been "the voice of the middle class against an aristocracy," especially in England. In the United States it had been identified with "the people," who were presumed to share the middle class values of education and rationality. But the forces of urbanization, immigration and mass journalism combined to give a new connotation to the term, Schudson observes.

Public opinion was no longer the readership James Gordon Bennett or Horace Greeley or Samuel Bowles addressed in small, dense type and long-winded editorials; the public was now the urban masses who

liked banner headlines, large drawings and photographs, snappy and spicy writing. True, the older journalism has scarcely been as dignified or reasoned as some liked to remember it, and the educated middle class itself liked banners and spice more than it cared to admit. But at the same time it felt a great need to distinguish itself from the rest of the reading public, for it no longer recognized in "public opinion" what it took to be its own voice, the voice of reason. The professional classes now took public opinion to be irrational and therefore something to study, direct, manipulate and control. The professions developed a proprietary attitude toward "reason" and a paternalistic attitude toward the public. (128-9)

Although the middle class professional--including the new breed of journalist--could look down on the public as crude and irrational, it was not possible to dismiss the public entirely. For in a democratic society the public was the only real source of authority, its perceptions the only sure guarantee of status. This is pointed out by Burton Bledstein in his study of professionalism in America. Bledstein views professionalism as the attempt of the middle class to assert its authority by laying claim to expert knowledge certified by university training. In pursuing this strategy the ascending professional class created a contradiction for itself-- the fact that in a democratic society one had to toil in the name of the public, (there being no other goal or body to serve), and yet distinguish one's self from the public in order to lay claim to a higher status and impress on the society the need for one's services. On the one hand, Bledstein notes, the aspiring



professional "identified with the public's interest" and asserted his belief in basic democratic values. On the other hand, he sought to establish his independence from "those he considered to be his inferiors," demanding, for example, the right of self-criticism (123). Not just for the press, then, but for professions in general, professionalism was both a dismissal and a glorification of the public. The profession claimed to have the "public interest" uppermost in mind, and, at the same time, asserted that the public was neither qualified to do what the professional did nor entitled to judge how well he did it.

For the press this dual claim presented a particularly tricky problem, for an assertion that the public was incompetent threatened to collapse the entire democratic mythos, and with it the source of the journalist's exalted place in society. It was one thing for doctors to claim that people could not understand modern medicine and therefore had no business treating themselves; it was quite another to say they did not understand their political system. Other professions could deliberately surround their subjects with arcane rituals and speak in a mysterious language, but for the press these strategies were clearly untenable. Journalism had to speak in a common language about subjects of public interest, and it had to insist that a public sharing this language and active in defending those interests was out there, demanding a responsible press.

This put the press in a nearly unique position among the professions. Most gain power and status by intimidating the layman into accepting the judgment of the "expert." The implication is always that people do not know enough or care enough to decide things for themselves. But the press built itself up by claiming the exact opposite: that people were not only competent to decide public questions but eager to do so, as long as they were furnished with the proper information. The equation is simple: the more active and able the public, the more vital and scared the functions of the press. Alone among the professions, journalism sponsors a myth of independence and competence, in which the average man's interest and ability as a political actor is built up along with the status of the press.

Of course, the journalist had an advantage over other aspiring professionals. He was relatively insulated from the public whose interests he had to serve. The public as a "client" of the journalist never appeared in the flesh, and made no direct demands on the professional. The point of contact between actual persons and working journalists was the newspaper, but the more the press could separate itself from the business of the newspaper--especially from the means through which the newspaper gained the attention of its readers--the less relevant this connection to actual people would be. As we have argued, this was the goal of professional training in journalism: to distinguish the

press as an institution from the newspaper as a business. To the degree that this project succeeded, the public could simply be made up, imagined in whatever shape the press desired, there being no mechanism by which an actual public could declare itself dissatisfied (or simply bored) with the service it was getting from the press. Since a professionalized press was, in effect, subsidized by those who did "some other kind of newspaper work," as Pulitzer put it, the press would not have the verdict of the marketplace hanging over its head. In fact, the more it ignored the marketplace, the more "professional" it would appear. Meanwhile, the press could borrow the mantle of the public's authority, and use it to justify everything it did, especially by use of the phrase "the public's right to know," and by invoking the sacred place of a free press in a democratic society. Thus we have a recent journalism textbook declaring that

Every journalist of consequence considers himself to be a public servant and believes that he and his organization are ultimately accountable to the public. On this base he rests his values. In a very real sense, therefore, he makes representative government possible, for he is the essential link between the governors and the governed. (Hohenberg 12)

Needless to say, there is no mention in the book of the actual means by which the "journalist of consequence" is held "ultimately accountable to the public," or even who this public is. There is no historical or critical

discussion of the "essential link between the governors and the governed," the implication being that it is pretty much the same as it was in 1789. Critical analysis is absent here because being a public servant in a professionalized press requires no demonstrable connection to an actual public; it is a self-declared status, or, as described rather candidly by Arthur Reed Kimball, "a feeling that comes over a person when he behaves in concert with his own conscience" (258). Kimball acknowledges that journalism's claim to professional status is not based on the independence of the journalist or on any esoteric knowledge he has mastered, but rather on a "sense of responsibility to the community, the loyalty to the public as a client above all other loyalties" (256).<sup>31</sup>

#### Answering to the community of journalists

Once again, the "sense of responsibility" journalists feel toward the public does not require any mechanism by which the journalist is held accountable to actual persons or groups of people. The only community to which the journalist must answer is the community of fellow journalists. This was another goal of Pulitzer in founding a professional school: to encourage journalists to identify with each other. At present, he noted, a journalist does not speak of another journalist as a colleague.

But if the future editors of the city were in large proportion graduates of the same college and had a recognized professional meeting-place in which they could come together informally and discuss matters of



common interest, would they not eventually develop a professional pride that would enable them to work in concert for the public good and that would put any black sheep of the profession in an uncomfortable position? (650)

As members of the press turned away from the demonstrated readership of the newspaper and those who catered to it, they turned toward each other. Local press clubs had been around since the 1870s, but they had a somewhat sullied reputation since many members were not journalists at all but politicians and businessmen hoping to influence the press (A.M. Lee 667-8). The National Press Club began in 1908, Sigma Delta Chi, the national fraternity of journalists, in 1909, the American Society of Newspaper Editors in 1922. Among the ASNE's first moves was to adopt its "Canons of Journalism" in 1923, a list of seven commandments dealing with accuracy, fairness and responsibility to the public. The seventh commandment, entitled "Decency," concluded with this interesting admission: "Lacking authority to enforce its canons, the journalism here represented can but express the hope that deliberate pandering to vicious instincts will encounter effective public disapproval or yield to the influence of a preponderant professional condemnation" (qtd. in MacDougall 62). In other words, the "Canons of Journalism" were purely symbolic, a list of shoulds and should-nots meant to impress the public and put fear in the hearts of wayward journalists. In law and medicine, "professional

condemnation" could include revoking the right to practice. But in journalism, all that existed to keep the professional in line was "contempt of his fellows," as one apologist for the press put it (Hamilton 648-9). On the reverse side, all that existed to put pride in the heart of the journalist was the respect of his fellows, there being no other mechanism by which a responsible and professional journalist could judge himself a success.

The fellowship among journalists encouraged by journalism schools, press clubs, professional associations and codes of ethics involved a further reorientation of attitudes toward the public. Esteem in the eyes of the community was replaced by esteem among one's colleagues, with the community becoming an abstract body, the public, whose perceptions about the press were to be influenced by the rituals of professionalization. Harry Christian has analyzed this shift in the British press. In the nineteenth century, he notes, most journalists were employed by small, local newspapers and concerned about their standing in the local community. The idea of journalism as a profession gave journalists "an alternative allegiance, namely to their colleagues," in which prestige was a fraternal judgment removed from the opinion of laymen (281). The public perception of journalists was still important, but a professional orientation created a new set of relationships among colleagues who together concerned themselves with

improving the image of the press in the eyes of the layman. Thus the importance of professional associations and codes of ethics. The public to which the modern journalist looked for recognition was not a known community of fellow residents whose opinion was valued in a personal way, but rather the general public--one might almost say "society"--which bestowed higher status on some professions than others. This more general and abstract public was reached not by personal contact but through symbols of authority and prestige. Thus, in 1890 a Royal Charter was granted to the Institute of Journalists, a professional association begun by members of the British press in 1880. The group to which the journalist owed his allegiance had by the twentieth century split into two groups: the immediate association with fellow journalists, and the distant ties to an abstract public conducted mainly through symbols like the Royal Charter or the Canons of Journalism.

#### The newsroom as an insulated environment

Today the professional journalist has little or no contact with actual readers or viewers, and prides himself on that fact. Sociologist Herbert Gans reports that journalists are not typically interested in their audiences, and when they are their judgments are often unsound, based on personal feeling or industry lore rather than empirical research. In Deciding What's News, a study of newsweeklies and network news operations, Gans writes:

I began this study with the assumption that journalists, as commercial employees, take the audience directly into account when selecting and producing stories; I therefore paid close attention to how the journalists conceived of and related to their audience. I was surprised to find, however, that they had little knowledge about the actual audience and rejected feedback from it. Although they had a vague image of the audience, they paid little attention to it; instead, they filmed and wrote for their superiors and for themselves, assuming... that what interested them would interest the audience. (229-30)

One of the reasons Gans gives for this lack of interest in actual readers and viewers is that journalists "are reluctant to accept any procedure which casts doubt on their news judgment and their professional autonomy" (232). Professionals pride themselves on writing and editing for an "interested" and educated audience, for that is the audience that grants them the most freedom to perform their sacred functions in a democracy. At the same time, journalists look down on what they assume most people want from the news. Gans observes that beneath

the rejection of audience wants and preferences lurks a further fear, also embodied in journalistic audience lore, that many viewers and readers are not particularly interested in the news they now receive, preferring gossip about celebrities to important activities of important actors. "They only want to know how the astronauts shit while they are in space," a producer working on a space-mission story once pointed out. (235)

There are, then, two images of the audience the professional journalist has in his head, both tending toward the mythic. One, which we can call the "public," is an imagined audience of educated and interested citizens, (much